EYES FIXED ON JESUS

Small-group kit

Thirteen sessions for home groups and small groups – one per chapter, 75 to 90 minutes each. Each session builds on the devotionals.

SESSION 1	The Final Word	Hebrews 1:1–14
SESSION 10	The New and Living Way	Hebrews 10:1–39
SESSION 11	By Faith	Hebrews 11:1–40
SESSION 12	The Race and the Mountain	Hebrews 12:1–29
SESSION 13	The Great Shepherd	Hebrews 13:1–25
SESSION 2	Do Not Drift	Hebrews 2:1–18
SESSION 3	Today	Hebrews 3:1–19
SESSION 4	The Promise of Rest	Hebrews 4:1–16
SESSION 5	Our Understanding High Priest	Hebrews 5:1–14
SESSION 6	The Soul's Anchor	Hebrews 6:1–20
SESSION 7	A Priest for Ever	Hebrews 7:1–28
SESSION 8	Shadow and Reality	Hebrews 8:1–13
SESSION 9	Through His Own Blood	Hebrews 9:1–28

Scripture: own translation from the Greek by Dr. Johannes A. Nortjé. Base text: SBL Greek New Testament, © 2010 Society of Biblical Literature and Logos Bible Software (CC BY 4.0).
© 2026 Dr. Johannes A. Nortjé · CC BY-NC-ND 4.0

SESSION 1 · HEBREWS 1:1–14

The Final Word

THE BIG IDEA

God has spoken his final word in his Son, who radiates his glory, carries all things, has made purification for sins and now reigns far above the angels – so we can rest in his finished work and anchor our lives in the one who remains the same.

TO GET STARTED

When you receive important news, how do you most want to hear it – by text message, as a rumour, or from the person themselves? Why?

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 1:1–14

Read in two parts: one reader takes verses 1–4 (a single long sentence in Greek – read it slowly, without stopping); in verses 5–14 one reader reads the linking words and a second reader the seven Old Testament quotations.

TIMING

10 min	Welcome & opener
10 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & original language
40 min	Discussion
15 min	Application & prayer

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Hebrews names no author and opens without a greeting. It reads like a sermon to a congregation of Jewish Christians (perhaps in or near Rome, cf. 13:24) who are under heavy pressure and tempted to go back to the visible temple service, the priesthood and the law of Moses. Tonight we read chapter 1: God's final word in the Son (vv. 1–4), and a string of seven Old Testament quotations showing that the Son is far above the angels (vv. 5–14).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

- ***apaugasma* – ἀπαύγασμα** "radiance": The radiance or shining-out of light. Just as you cannot separate the sun from its rays, Christ is the visible radiance of God's invisible glory – he does not merely reflect God's light as the moon reflects the sun, he radiates God's own glory (1:3).
- ***charaktēr* – χαρακτήρ** "very stamp": The source of our word character: the exact impression a signet ring makes in warm wax, or the image struck on a coin, showing every finest line of the original. Christ is the exact expression of God's being (hypostasis, 1:3).
- ***leitourgika pneumata* – λειτουργικὰ πνεύματα** "ministering spirits": Literally liturgical, serving spirits. No angel was ever told to sit at God's right hand (Psalm 110:1); the angels are heaven's support staff – sent out to serve those who are going to inherit salvation (1:14).

DISCUSSION

1. In Greek, verses 1–4 are a single sentence. In the past God spoke "in many parts and in many ways"; now "he has spoken to us through the Son". What is the difference between receiving messages from God and receiving his Son as his final word? (Hebrews 1:1–2)
2. Christ is "the radiance of his glory and the very stamp of his being". If you want to know what God is like, where do you look – and what do you see in Jesus? (Hebrews 1:3)
3. "He carries all things by the powerful word." The devotional describes this carrying as moving something forward to a destination, not balancing a dead weight like Atlas. Which part of your life feels as if it is falling apart – and what changes if he is carrying it? (Hebrews 1:3)

4. The tabernacle had no chair for the priests; their work was never finished. But “when he himself had made purification for sins, he took his seat”. Where are you still standing – trying to earn God's favour – instead of resting in his finished work? (Hebrews 1:3–4)
5. The first readers were tempted to fall back on what was visible, familiar and impressive. We may not bow before angels today – which substitutes fascinate us more than Jesus himself? (Hebrews 1:4–7)
6. The Father says to the Son: “Your throne, O God, stands for ever and ever.” What does it mean for us that the one who was crucified is addressed as God and reigns? (Hebrews 1:8–9)
7. “But you are the same, and your years will never come to an end.” Bodies grow old, relationships change, economies falter. Where do you need the unchanging Christ this week? And how does verse 14 comfort you – angels “sent out to serve for the sake of those who are going to inherit salvation”? (Hebrews 1:10–14)

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Each morning this week, before you look at the news or your phone, read Hebrews 1:3 and name one burden you are handing over to the one who carries all things.
- Name one area where you still try to do enough for God before you dare to come to him. Thank him in so many words that the purification is finished and that he has sat down.

PRAY TOGETHER

Begin by reading verses 1–3 aloud together, slowly. Then pray in pairs: worship the Son for who he is (the radiance of God's glory, the very stamp of his being, the one who carries all things, the King), name one thing that feels out of control, and give it to him. Close by thanking God that his angels serve those who are going to inherit salvation.

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- This session covers two devotionals (days 1–2). The chapter is dense; choose four or five questions and keep time for the last one.
- Authorship: Hebrews names no author. If the group asks who wrote it, simply say that the letter does not tell us, and move on – it is not the topic of the evening.
- Verse 6: firstborn (prōtotokos) is about rank, authority and the right of inheritance, not about Jesus having a beginning – David is called firstborn in Psalm 89:27, although he was Jesse's youngest son. In the same way “today I have fathered you” (v. 5) points in the New Testament to his enthronement as the risen Messiah-King (Acts 13:33; Romans 1:4), not to a moment when he was created.
- Hebrews quotes the Old Testament in its Greek form (the Septuagint), and our translation renders the quotations as Hebrews has them. The line in verse 6 comes from Deuteronomy 32:43 in the Septuagint and is missing from the Hebrew text. If someone compares with their Old Testament and notices differences, that is the reason.
- Angels can become a long side-track (guardian angels, experiences, speculation). Bring the group back to the chapter's point: the angels serve; the Son reigns and is worshipped.
- Point ahead: next week chapter 2 – the danger of drifting, and Jesus, who is not ashamed to call us brothers and sisters.

Related devotionals: Day 1 – The Final Word: Christ, the Radiance of God's Glory · Day 2 – Exalted above the Angels: The Eternal King and Ministering Spirits

Hebrews 1:1–14

[1] In many parts and in many ways God spoke in
the past to the fathers through the prophets;
[2] at the end of these days he has spoken to us
through the Son. Him he appointed heir of ev-
erything, and through him he also made the
worlds. [3] He is the radiance of his glory and the
very stamp of his being, and he carries all
things by the powerful word. When he himself
had made purification for sins, he took his seat
at the right hand of the Majesty on high, [4] and
so he has become as much better than the an-
gels as the name he has inherited is superior to
theirs.

[5] For to which of the angels did he ever say:

You are my Son;
today I have fathered you?
And again:
I will be a father to him,
and he will be a son to me?

[6] And when he again brings the firstborn into
the world, he says:

And let all God's angels worship him.

[7] With regard to the angels he says:

He makes his angels winds,
and his ministers a flame of fire.

[8] But with regard to the Son:

Your throne, O God, stands for ever and ever,
and the sceptre of uprightness is the sceptre of
your kingdom.
[9] You have loved righteousness and hated
lawlessness;
therefore God, your God, has anointed you
with the oil of rejoicing beyond your partners.

[10] And:

In the beginning, Lord, you laid the foundation
of the earth,
and the heavens are the works of your hands.
[11] They will perish, but you remain;
they will all wear out like a garment,
[12] and like a cloak you will roll them up;
like a garment they will also be changed.
But you are the same,
and your years will never come to an end.

[13] But to which of the angels has he ever said:

Sit at my right hand
until I make your enemies
a footstool for your feet?

[14] Are they not all ministering spirits, sent out
to serve for the sake of those who are going to
inherit salvation?

SESSION 10 · HEBREWS 10:1–39

The New and Living Way

THE BIG IDEA

By one offering Christ has made perfect for all time those who are made holy; so let us approach God, hold fast to our hope and consider one another – and not throw away our confidence, for the one who is coming will come.

TO GET STARTED

Think of something you had to repeat again and again – a medicine, a repair, a chore. How do you know when a problem has been fixed for good?

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 10:1–39

Three readers: verses 1–18 (one sacrifice – read the Psalm in verses 5–7 as the voice of the Son), verses 19–25 (one long sentence in the Greek – listen for the three "let us"), verses 26–39 (warning and encouragement – pause briefly after verse 31).

TIMING

10 min	Welcome & opener
10 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & original language
40 min	Discussion
15 min	Application & prayer

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Chapter 10 brings the great teaching on Christ as high priest to its closing chord: the yearly sacrifices only reminded people of their sins, but Christ's one offering has done what they never could (10:1–18). Then, at 10:19, the letter turns from what Christ has done to how we are to live: three times "let us". A fourth serious warning follows (10:26–31), and then warm encouragement that leads into the great faith chapter, Hebrews 11.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

- ***teteleiōken … tous hagiazomenous* – τετελείωκεν … τοὺς ἁγιαζομένους** "he has made perfect … those who are made holy": Two tenses side by side in 10:14: a perfect tense – our standing before God is already settled – and a present participle – we are being made holy day by day. Already perfect in God's eyes, and still growing.
- ***prosphatos* – πρόσφατος** "new": Originally fresh, recently made. The way Jesus inaugurated through the curtain (10:20) always stays fresh: his sacrifice is as powerful before God today as on the day of the cross – and because he is risen, it is a living way.
- ***parrēsia* – παρρησία** "confidence": A free, unhindered right of access: we have confidence to enter the sanctuary by the blood of Jesus (10:19). In 10:35 the same word returns: don't throw it away – like a soldier who throws away his shield and flees.

DISCUSSION

1. If a medicine really cures, you stop taking it. "In these sacrifices there is a reminder of sins year after year" – but verse 18 says: "Where there is forgiveness of these, there is no longer any offering for sin." Where do we set up little side altars next to the cross – punishing ourselves or doing penance before we accept forgiveness? (Hebrews 10:1–4)
2. "See, I have come to do your will." God was looking not for mere rituals but for a body willing to do his will. What would it look like to put your everyday body – your time, your work, your family life – at his disposal this week? (Hebrews 10:5–10)

3. Every priest stands day after day; this one offered one sacrifice and took his seat. “For by one offering he has made perfect for all time those who are made holy.” How does this verse help when you are discouraged by how slowly you change? (Hebrews 10:11–18)
4. Verses 19–23 rest on two possessions – the open way and a great priest – and call us to approach and to hold fast, “for the one who made the promise is faithful”. Why does it matter that our holding on rests on his faithfulness rather than on the strength of our grip? (Hebrews 10:19–23)
5. “And let us consider one another, so as to spur one another on to love and good works.” The same verb is used in 3:1 for considering Jesus. What would it look like for us as a group to consider one another in this way – and who among us needs encouraging right now? (Hebrews 10:24–25)
6. Verses 26–31 are among the most serious words in the letter: “To fall into the hands of the living God is a fearful thing.” Yet straight after them the author writes: “But remember the earlier days”. Why do warning and encouragement belong together here? (Hebrews 10:26–31)
7. The readers had once accepted the loss of their possessions with joy, knowing they had a better possession, one that lasts. “So do not throw away your confidence, which has a great reward.” Which earlier struggle, through which God carried you, gives you courage for the present one? (Hebrews 10:32–39)

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Name one side altar in your life – a way you try to pay for your own failures – and each time you notice it this week, read verse 18 and receive forgiveness instead.
- Consider one person this week – perhaps someone who has been missing from your meetings – and spur them on with a visit, a call or a message of encouragement.

PRAY TOGETHER

Begin by reading verses 22–24 aloud together. Then pray in three movements: approach God with thanks for the open way through Jesus' blood; hold fast – bring to God the places where your hope is under pressure; consider one another – pray by name for one person in the group. Close together with verse 39.

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- This session draws on three devotionals (days 19–21), and chapter 10 has 39 verses. If time is short, read verses 1–18 in one go and spend more time on verses 19–39. Choose five questions.
- In 10:5 our text reads “but a body you have prepared for me”, as Hebrews quotes Psalm 40 from the Greek. The Hebrew of Psalm 40:6 says, literally, ears you have dug for me. If the group's Bibles differ, that is the reason; the devotional suggests the part (the ears) may stand for the whole (the body).
- 10:26–31 and different convictions: Christians in your group may understand these verses differently, especially on the question whether a true believer can finally fall away. Let people speak and listen respectfully; you don't need to settle the debate. Keep to what the day 21 devotional says: the warning concerns apostasy – deliberately and persistently turning one's back on Christ after receiving the knowledge of the truth – not a believer who stumbles through weakness and returns in repentance (4:15–16). Whoever rejects the one sacrifice has no other left.
- Tender consciences: some will fear they have committed this sin. The devotionals answer that for the believer who takes refuge in Christ, the hands of the living God are the safest place (John 10:28–29), and (day 11, on 6:4–6) that a tender heart that grieves over sin and longs for Jesus is itself proof of not being in that hardened state. Say this clearly, and offer to talk afterwards.
- Two smaller points to handle with care: the devotional reads “our bodies washed with pure water” (10:22) as pointing to baptism – groups may hold different views on baptism, so don't let it become a debate. And verse 25 is about encouraging, not policing: some miss meetings because of illness, shift work or caring for others.
- Point ahead: verse 39 builds the bridge to chapter 11 – next week the nature of faith and the great witnesses of the past.

Related devotionals: Day 19 – One Sacrifice for All Time: The Perfect Obedience That Makes Holy · Day 20 – The New and Living Way: Let Us Approach with Confidence and Hold Fast · Day 21 – Endurance in Faith: Do Not Throw Away Your Confidence

Hebrews 10:1–39

1 For the law has only a shadow of the good
things to come, not the very form of the realities. So it can never, by the same sacrifices that
they offer continually year after year, make perfect those who approach. 2 Otherwise, would
they not have stopped being offered? For the
worshippers, once cleansed, would no longer
have any sins on their conscience. 3 But in these
sacrifices there is a reminder of sins year after
year. 4 For it is impossible for the blood of bulls
and goats to take away sins.

5 Therefore, when he comes into the world, he
says:

Sacrifice and offering you did not want,
but a body you have prepared for me;
6 in burnt offerings and sin offerings
you took no pleasure.
7 Then I said: See, I have come –
in the scroll of the book it is written of me –
to do your will, O God.

8 Above he says: "Sacrifices and offerings and
burnt offerings and sin offerings you did not
want, nor did you take pleasure in them" – these
are offered according to the law. 9 Then he has
said: "See, I have come to do your will." He takes
away the first in order to establish the second.
10 By this will we have been made holy through
the offering of the body of Jesus Christ once for
all.

11 Every priest stands day after day ministering
and offering again and again the same sacrifices, which can never take away sins. 12 But this
one offered one sacrifice for sins for all time
and took his seat at the right hand of God, 13 and
from then on he waits until his enemies are
made a footstool for his feet. 14 For by one offering he has made perfect for all time those who
are made holy. 15 And the Holy Spirit also testifies to us; for after saying:

16 This is the covenant that I will make with
them
after those days, says the Lord:
I will put my laws on their hearts,
and I will write them on their minds,
17 and their sins and their lawless deeds
I will remember no more.

18 Where there is forgiveness of these, there is
no longer any offering for sin.

19 So, brothers and sisters, since we have confidence to enter the sanctuary by the blood of
Jesus, 20 by the new and living way that he inaugurated for us through the curtain, that is, his
flesh, 21 and since we have a great priest over the
house of God, 22 let us approach with a true
heart in full assurance of faith, with our hearts
sprinkled clean from an evil conscience and our
bodies washed with pure water. 23 Let us hold
fast to the confession of hope, unwavering, for
the one who made the promise is faithful.
24 And let us consider one another, so as to spur
one another on to love and good works, 25 not
abandoning our own meeting together, as is the
habit of some, but encouraging one another,
and all the more as you see the Day drawing
near.

26 For if we sin deliberately after we have received the knowledge of the truth, there no
longer remains a sacrifice for sins, 27 but only a
fearful expectation of judgment and the fury of
a fire that will consume the adversaries.
28 Anyone who has set aside the law of Moses
dies without pity on the testimony of two or
three witnesses. 29 How much worse punishment, do you think, will be deserved by the one
who has trampled on the Son of God, has regarded as unclean the blood of the covenant by
which he was made holy, and has insulted the
Spirit of grace? 30 For we know the one who
said:

Vengeance is mine; I will repay.

And again:
The Lord will judge his people.

[31] To fall into the hands of the living God is a fearful thing.

[32] But remember the earlier days, when, after you had been enlightened, you endured a hard struggle with sufferings, [33] sometimes being made a public spectacle through reproaches and afflictions, and sometimes standing in fellowship with those who were treated in this way. [34] For you sympathized with the prisoners, and you accepted the seizure of your possessions with joy, knowing that you yourselves have a better possession, one that lasts. [35] So do not throw away your confidence, which has a great reward. [36] For you need endurance, so that when you have done the will of God you may receive the promise.

[37] For yet a very little while,
and the one who is coming will come and will not delay;
[38] but my righteous one will live by faith,
and if he draws back,
my soul takes no pleasure in him.

[39] But we are not of those who draw back to destruction, but of those who have faith to the preserving of the soul.

SESSION 11 · HEBREWS 11:1–40

By Faith

THE BIG IDEA

Faith treats God's promises as a title deed in our hand: it makes us pilgrims on the way to the city whose builder is God, it values the reproach of the Christ above the treasures of Egypt, and it holds on – whether God delivers us or carries us through suffering.

TO GET STARTED

Have you ever paid for something long before you could enjoy it – a ticket, a plot of land, a holiday? What did it feel like to hold the proof in your hand while you were still waiting?

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 11:1–40

Use four readers: verses 1–7 (faith and the first witnesses), 8–22 (Abraham to Joseph), 23–31 (Moses to Rahab), 32–40 (the heroes and the nameless). Let the whole group say the words "By faith" together each time they come.

TIMING

10 min	Welcome & opener
15 min	Read the passage
5 min	Background & original language
40 min	Discussion
15 min	Application & prayer

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

At the end of chapter 10 the author reminded his tired, persecuted readers that they are not of those who draw back, but of those who have faith. Now he opens a gallery of witnesses from their own Scriptures – from Abel, Enoch and Noah, through Abraham and the patriarchs, to Moses, Rahab and nameless martyrs. None of them lived by what their eyes could see; all of them lived by God's promises. Tonight we read the whole of chapter 11.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

- ***hypostasis* – ὑπόστασις** "assurance": We met this word in 1:3 ("being") and 3:14 ("assurance"). In some Greek papyri of the first centuries it is used for documents that prove ownership – a kind of title deed. Faith holds the title deed of God's promises before we have moved in (11:1).
- ***aspazomai* – ἀσπάζομαι** "greeted": To welcome something with joy, to embrace it with open arms – like sailors who see the hills of home on the horizon and cheer, though they are still miles from the harbour. The patriarchs died without the fulfilment, but they saw the promises from afar and greeted them (11:13).
- ***kartereō* – καρτερέω** "held on": Like a soldier who stays standing, strong and unshaken. This is the secret of Moses' staying power: when you see the invisible King with the eye of faith, the fury of an earthly pharaoh shrinks to nothing (11:27).

DISCUSSION

1. "Now faith is the assurance of what is hoped for, the proof of things that are not seen." The devotional compares this assurance to a title deed. What is the difference between treating a promise of God as a title deed and treating it as a wish? (Hebrews 11:1–3)
2. Abel shows the worship of faith, Enoch its daily walk, Noah its work and perseverance. Verse 6 says that whoever approaches God must believe that he exists and that he "rewards those who earnestly seek him". How does that picture of God change the way you pray? (Hebrews 11:4–7)

3. Abraham “went out, not knowing where he was going”. When have you had to take a step of obedience without seeing the whole map? What helped you take it? (Hebrews 11:8–12)
4. The patriarchs confessed that they were “strangers and temporary residents on the earth”. Where do we drive our tent pegs too deep into this world? And what does it mean to you that “God is not ashamed of them, to be called their God”? (Hebrews 11:13–16)
5. On Moriah Abraham “reckoned that God is able even to raise from the dead”. What is the “Isaac” in your life – a good gift from God that you may be clinging to more tightly than to the Giver? (Hebrews 11:17–22)
6. Moses “considered the reproach of the Christ greater wealth than the treasures of Egypt”. What are today's treasures of Egypt, and what helps us see through “the fleeting enjoyment of sin”? (Hebrews 11:23–28)
7. In verses 33–35 some shut the mouths of lions; then the text turns: “Others were tortured and refused to accept release”. Both groups stand in the same list, and of the suffering ones it says “the world was not worthy of them”. How can this help someone in a long, hard season? (Hebrews 11:32–40)

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Write down one promise of God you are holding on to without yet seeing it fulfilled. Read it every morning this week as a title deed, and thank God for it before you see anything change.
- Name one tent peg that holds you too tightly to this world – a possession, an ambition or a worry – and do one concrete thing this week to loosen it: give something away, share, or hand it over to God in prayer.

PRAY TOGETHER

Begin by reading verse 1 aloud together. Thank God for the people of faith who went before you, in the Bible and in your own life. Then pray for anyone in the group who is in an “Others” season – waiting, suffering or not yet seeing an answer – and ask that all of you may hold on as those who see the invisible One.

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- This session covers three devotionals (days 22–24) and 40 verses. Don't try to discuss every name; the four reading parts give the structure, and four or five questions are enough.
- 11:11: our translation follows the Greek base text, in which Abraham is the subject (“together with Sarah herself”); many older Bibles make Sarah the subject. If someone notices the difference, explain it briefly – verse 12 also speaks of “one man” – and point out that Sarah is still included. Don't let it become the topic of the evening.
- The most sensitive point is verses 35–38. Some people believe that great faith always brings healing or rescue. The day 24 devotional says that those who suffered did not have less faith than those who saw miracles. Handle this gently with anyone who is ill, grieving or has prayed long without an answer, and don't promise outcomes.
- Abel's sacrifice: the devotional explains God's acceptance by the faith of Abel's heart. Genesis says little about the reason, so don't spend long on speculation about the offerings.
- Verses 39–40 prepare for next week: the witnesses of chapter 11 are made perfect together with us. Point ahead: chapter 12 – the race, the Father's discipline and the two mountains, Sinai and Zion.

Related devotionals: Day 22 – The Nature of Faith and the First Heroes of Faith: Abel, Enoch and Noah · Day 23 – Pilgrims and Strangers Seeking the Eternal City: From Abraham to Joseph · Day 24 – Moses and the Nameless Victors: Worth More than the Treasures of Egypt

Hebrews 11:1–40

[1] Now faith is the assurance of what is hoped
for, the proof of things that are not seen. [2] For
by it the people of old were attested. [3] By faith
we understand that the worlds were fashioned
by God's word, so that what is seen did not
come into being out of things that appear.

[4] By faith Abel offered God a greater sacrifice
than Cain. Through it he was attested as right-
eous, God himself testifying about his gifts; and
through it, though he died, he is still speaking.
[5] By faith Enoch was taken up so that he would
not see death, and "he was not found, because
God had taken him up". For before he was taken
up, it was testified of him that he had pleased
God. [6] And without faith it is impossible to
please him, for whoever approaches God must
believe that he exists and that he rewards those
who earnestly seek him. [7] By faith Noah, when
he was warned by God about things not yet
seen, in reverence built an ark for the salvation
of his house. Through it he condemned the
world, and he became heir of the righteousness
that accords with faith.

[8] By faith Abraham obeyed when he was called
to go out to a place that he was to receive as an
inheritance; and he went out, not knowing
where he was going. [9] By faith he lived as a
guest in the land of the promise as in a foreign
land, living in tents with Isaac and Jacob, co-
heirs of the same promise. [10] For he was waiting
for the city that has the foundations, whose de-
signer and builder is God. [11] By faith he received
power to father offspring – together with Sarah
herself – even when he was past the age for it,
since he considered the one who had promised
faithful. [12] Therefore from one man, and him as
good as dead, descendants were born as many
as the stars of heaven and as countless as the
sand on the shore of the sea.

[13] In faith all these died without having received
the promises, but they saw them from afar and
greeted them, and confessed that they were
strangers and temporary residents on the
earth. [14] For people who speak like this make it
clear that they are seeking a homeland. [15] If
they had been thinking of the one they had left,
they would have had opportunity to return.
[16] But as it is, they long for a better one, that is, a
heavenly one. Therefore God is not ashamed of
them, to be called their God; for he has pre-
pared a city for them.

[17] By faith Abraham, when he was tested, of-
fered up Isaac. He who had received the prom-
ises was ready to offer up his only son, [18] he to
whom it had been said, "Through Isaac off-
spring will be named for you." [19] He reckoned
that God is able even to raise from the dead;
hence he did receive him back – as a symbol.
[20] By faith Isaac blessed Jacob and Esau, also
concerning things to come. [21] By faith Jacob,
when he was dying, blessed each of the sons of
Joseph, and he worshipped, leaning on the top
of his staff. [22] By faith Joseph, at the end of his
life, mentioned the exodus of the sons of Israel
and gave instructions about his bones.

[23] By faith Moses, after he was born, was hidden
for three months by his parents, because they
saw that the child was beautiful, and they were
not afraid of the king's edict. [24] By faith Moses,
when he had grown up, refused to be called the
son of Pharaoh's daughter, [25] choosing rather to
be mistreated along with the people of God
than to have the fleeting enjoyment of sin, [26] for
he considered the reproach of the Christ
greater wealth than the treasures of Egypt, be-
cause he had his eyes fixed on the reward. [27] By
faith he left Egypt, not fearing the fury of the
king; for he held on as though he saw the one
who is invisible. [28] By faith he instituted the
Passover and the applying of the blood, so that
the destroyer of the firstborn would not touch
them. [29] By faith they crossed the Red Sea as on

dry land; when the Egyptians attempted it,
they were swallowed up. [30] By faith the walls of
Jericho fell after they had been encircled for
seven days. [31] By faith Rahab the prostitute did
not perish with those who disobeyed, because
she had welcomed the spies in peace.

[32] And what more shall I say? Time would fail
me if I told of Gideon, Barak, Samson,
Jephthah, of David and Samuel and the
prophets, [33] who through faith conquered king-
doms, practised righteousness, obtained prom-
ises, shut the mouths of lions, [34] quenched the
power of fire, escaped the edge of the sword,
were made strong out of weakness, became
mighty in war, put foreign armies to flight.
[35] Women received back their dead by resurrec-
tion. Others were tortured and refused to ac-
cept release, so that they might obtain a better
resurrection. [36] Still others experienced mock-
ing and flogging, and even chains and prison.
[37] They were stoned, they were sawn in two,
they died by the sword; they went about in
sheepskins and goatskins, in want, afflicted,
mistreated – [38] the world was not worthy of
them – wandering in deserts and mountains, in
caves and holes in the ground.

[39] And all these, though they were attested
through their faith, did not receive the prom-
ise, [40] since God had foreseen something better
for us, so that they would not be made perfect
apart from us.

SESSION 12 · HEBREWS 12:1–29

The Race and the Mountain

THE BIG IDEA

With our eyes fixed on Jesus we run the race with endurance and accept the Father's discipline as love; and because we have approached Mount Zion, not Sinai, we receive a kingdom that cannot be shaken and worship God with gratitude, reverence and awe.

TO GET STARTED

Think of a time you finished something long and hard – a race, a climb, a project – when you felt like giving up halfway. What kept you going?

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 12:1–29

Use four readers: verses 1–13 (the race and the Father's discipline), 14–21 (Esau and Mount Sinai – read 18–21 slowly and heavily), 22–24 (Mount Zion – read with joy, so the contrast is heard), 25–29 (the kingdom that cannot be shaken).

TIMING

10 min	Welcome & opener
10 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & original language
40 min	Discussion
15 min	Application & prayer

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Chapter 11 ended with a great gallery of witnesses; now the baton is placed in our hands. The first readers were worn out, like long-distance runners with a cramp halfway through a marathon. In chapter 12 the author gives them new strength with three pictures: a stadium (verses 1–3), a family home where children are raised (verses 4–13), and two mountains – Sinai and Zion (verses 18–24) – followed by the last warning of the letter (verses 25–29).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

- ***aphorōntes* – ἀφορῶντες** "with our eyes fixed on": The prefix apo- (away from) means that you deliberately turn your eyes away from everything else to fix them on one point: Jesus, "the pioneer of faith and the one who brings it to perfection" (12:2). No runner wins by looking at his own feet or at the crowd.
- ***paideia* – παιδεία** "discipline": From pais (child): the whole process of raising a child, forming character and loving correction. A court's punishment looks back at the offence in order to repay it – and our punishment has already fallen on Jesus; the Father's paideia looks forward to the child's growth (12:5–11).
- ***panēgyris* – πανήγυρις** "festal gathering": A great national festival, as at the Olympic Games when the whole city celebrated. At Sinai the angels surrounded the awe-inspiring giving of the law; at Zion they celebrate the redemption of sinners (12:22).

DISCUSSION

1. We have "such a vast cloud of witnesses surrounding us" – not spectators waiting for us to fall, but witnesses who testify through their own race that God's promises hold. Which "weight" – perhaps not even a sin – is slowing you down at the moment? (Hebrews 12:1)
2. "For the sake of the joy that lay before him he endured the cross, despising the shame." What does it mean in practice to keep your eyes fixed on Jesus when you feel overwhelmed by opposition, injustice

or your own weakness? (Hebrews 12:2–3)

3. Verse 5 warns against two opposite reactions to hardship: “do not make light of the discipline of the Lord” and “do not lose heart”. Which of the two is more your tendency? How does it change things to see hardship as the Father's training rather than his punishment? (Hebrews 12:4–10)
4. “Later, however, it yields the peaceful fruit of righteousness to those who have been trained by it.” Can you tell of a hard season in which you only saw the fruit later? (Hebrews 12:11–13)
5. Esau “sold his birthright for a single meal”, and a root of bitterness can defile many. What “single meal” tempts us today? And how can we, as a group, “see to it” for one another without becoming judgemental? (Hebrews 12:14–17)
6. Compare the two mountains: what do you see, hear and feel at Sinai (verses 18–21) and at Zion (verses 22–24)? When you pray, do you approach God more like Sinai or like Zion? (Hebrews 12:18–24)
7. The blood of Jesus “speaks better than Abel”, and “since we are receiving a kingdom that cannot be shaken, let us be thankful”. What is being shaken around you at the moment, and what would thankful worship look like as your answer? (Hebrews 12:24–29)

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Name one “weight” and put it down this week in a concrete way – an evening without a screen, a commitment you hand back, a worry you give to God in prayer each morning.
- If a root of bitterness has begun to grow towards someone, take one step this week towards peace: pray for that person by name, send a message, or ask for a conversation.

PRAY TOGETHER

Begin by reading verse 2 aloud together. Keep a minute of silence in which each person lays down a weight before God. Then pray for those in the group who feel tired in the race, thank God that in Christ we have approached Mount Zion, and close by reading verses 28–29 together.

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- This session covers two devotionals (days 25–26) and three big pictures. If time is short, focus on verses 1–3 and 18–24, and choose one question from the discipline passage.
- Verses 5–11 can be painful for people who had a harsh or abusive father, and the words “he flogs every son” can sound frightening. Stay with the devotional: paideia is not punishment, it looks forward in love, and God disciplines “for our good”. Don't suggest that a particular illness or loss is God's punishment for a particular sin.
- 12:17 (Esau “found no place for repentance”) can frighten sensitive believers who fear they have gone too far. The day 26 devotional says that Esau's tears were only regret over his loss, not true repentance towards God. Someone who is troubled about this is showing the opposite of Esau's indifference; offer a personal conversation if needed.
- Verses 25–29 are the letter's last warning. The devotional holds both together: the God of Zion is the same consuming fire as the God of Sinai, but in Christ our fear becomes grateful reverence. Don't let either side drop out.
- Translation: in 12:2 our text has “the pioneer of faith and the one who brings it to perfection” instead of the familiar wording of older Bibles; it stays close to the Greek archēgos (already in 2:10) and teleiōtēs. The series title comes from this verse.
- Point ahead: next week chapter 13, the last session – love in practice, outside the camp, and the great shepherd.

Related devotionals: Day 25 – The Race of Endurance: Eyes Fixed on Jesus and the Father's Discipline · Day 26 – Sinai and Zion: Receiving a Kingdom That Cannot Be Shaken

Hebrews 12:1–29

1 Therefore, since we too have such a vast cloud
of witnesses surrounding us, let us lay aside every weight and the sin that so readily wraps itself around us, and let us run with endurance
the race that lies before us, 2 with our eyes fixed
on Jesus, the pioneer of faith and the one who
brings it to perfection. For the sake of the joy
that lay before him he endured the cross, despising the shame, and he has taken his seat at
the right hand of the throne of God. 3 Consider
him who endured such opposition from sinners
against themselves, so that you do not grow
weary and lose heart in your souls.

4 In your struggle against sin you have not yet
resisted to the point of blood, 5 and you have
forgotten the encouragement that addresses
you as sons:

My son, do not make light of the discipline of
the Lord,
and do not lose heart when you are corrected by
him;
6 for the Lord disciplines the one he loves,
and he flogs every son whom he accepts.

7 It is for discipline that you endure. God is
treating you as sons. For what son is there
whom a father does not discipline? 8 But if you
are without the discipline that all have come to
share in, then you are illegitimate and not sons.
9 Besides, we had the fathers of our flesh to discipline us, and we respected them. Shall we not
much more submit to the Father of spirits and
live? 10 For they disciplined us for a few days as
seemed good to them, but he does it for our
good, so that we may share in his holiness. 11 All
discipline, for the moment, seems to be a matter not of joy but of sorrow; later, however, it
yields the peaceful fruit of righteousness to
those who have been trained by it.

12 Therefore lift up again the drooping hands
and the weakened knees, 13 and make straight
paths for your feet, so that what is lame may
not be put out of joint but rather be healed.

14 Pursue peace with everyone, and holiness,
without which no one will see the Lord. 15 See to
it that no one falls short of the grace of God,
that no root of bitterness springs up and causes
trouble, and through it many are defiled, 16 that
no one is sexually immoral or godless like Esau,
who sold his birthright for a single meal. 17 For
you know that later, when he wanted to inherit
the blessing, he was rejected; for he found no
place for repentance, although he sought it
with tears.

18 For you have not approached something that
could be touched, and blazing fire, and darkness and gloom and storm, 19 and the sound of a
trumpet and a voice speaking words, whose
hearers begged that no further word be spoken
to them, 20 for they could not bear the command, "Even if an animal touches the mountain, it shall be stoned." 21 And so terrifying was
the sight that Moses said, "I am full of fear and
trembling." 22 But you have approached Mount
Zion and the city of the living God, the heavenly Jerusalem, and myriads of angels, the festal gathering 23 and assembly of the firstborn
who are enrolled in the heavens, and God, the
judge of all, and the spirits of the righteous who
have been made perfect, 24 and Jesus, the mediator of a new covenant, and the blood of sprinkling that speaks better than Abel.

25 See that you do not refuse the one who is
speaking. For if they did not escape when they
refused the one who warned them on earth,
much less shall we, if we turn away from the
one who warns from heaven. 26 His voice shook
the earth then, but now he has promised:

Once more I will shake not only the earth
but also heaven.

[27] This "Once more" shows that what is shaken will be removed, as things that have been made, so that what is not shaken may remain. [28] Therefore, since we are receiving a kingdom that cannot be shaken, let us be thankful, and so worship God in a way that pleases him, with reverence and awe; [29] for our God is indeed a consuming fire.

SESSION 13 · HEBREWS 13:1–25

The Great Shepherd

THE BIG IDEA

Grateful worship in a kingdom that cannot be shaken becomes practical love, contentment and the courage to go out to Jesus outside the camp; we offer God the sacrifices of praise and sharing – and the God of peace, who brought up the great shepherd from the dead, himself equips us to do his will.

TO GET STARTED

When a long time together comes to an end – a trip, a course, a job – what do you most want the others to take with them?

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 13:1–25

Use three readers: verses 1–9, 10–19 and 22–25. Let the whole group read verse 8 together, and read verses 20–21 together as a blessing at the end of the reading.

TIMING

10 min	Welcome & opener
10 min	Read the passage
5 min	Background & original language
40 min	Discussion
20 min	Application & prayer

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

At the end of chapter 12 the author said that we are receiving a kingdom that cannot be shaken and should worship God with thankfulness, reverence and awe. Chapter 13 shows what that worship looks like on an ordinary weekday: love, hospitality, marriage and money (verses 1–6), leaders and the unchanging Christ (7–9), going out to Jesus outside the camp (10–14), the sacrifices of praise and sharing (15–19), and finally a great blessing and personal greetings (20–25). Tonight we finish the letter – and this series.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

- ***ou mē se anō oud' ou mē se enkalipō* – οὐ μή σε ἀνῶ οὐδ' οὐ μή σε ἐγκαταλίπω** "never … never": In 13:5 the Greek piles up five negatives: freely rendered: I will never, ever loosen my grip on you, and I will never, ever abandon you. Our security lies not in what we have, but in whom we have – that is why we can be content (13:5–6).
- ***exō tēs parembolēs* – ἔξω τῆς παρεμβολῆς** "outside the camp": On the Day of Atonement the bodies of the sin offerings were burned outside the camp (Leviticus 16:27). Jesus suffered outside the gate. For the first readers the camp was the safe, respected world of the temple – but Jesus is outside (13:11–13).
- ***katartizō* – καταρτίζω** "equip": Used in medicine for setting a broken bone and by fishermen for mending nets (Matthew 4:21); in 11:3 the same verb describes the worlds being fashioned by God's word. What God asks of us, he himself works in us (13:21).

DISCUSSION

1. Verses 1–4 name four directions of love: love for brothers and sisters, hospitality to strangers, compassion for prisoners and the mistreated, and honour for marriage. Which of these is strong in our group, and which needs our attention? (Hebrews 13:1–4)
2. "Be content with what you have" – and the reason given is not a budget but a promise: "I will never let you go and never abandon you." Why does contentment rest on a person rather than on possessions? Where are you uneasy about money or the future? (Hebrews 13:5–6)
3. "Jesus Christ is yesterday and today the same – and for ever." Think of your own yesterday, today and future: where do you most need to hear this sentence? (Hebrews 13:7–8)

4. “It is good for the heart to be strengthened by grace, not by foods.” What are today's “foods” – rules, achievements or forms we use to feel in control? What does it look like to let grace strengthen your heart? (Hebrews 13:9)
5. “So let us go out to him outside the camp, bearing his reproach.” What is the comfortable “camp” in our setting, and what could going out to Jesus look like for you this month? (Hebrews 13:10–14)
6. Verses 15–16 name two sacrifices: “the fruit of lips that confess his name” and “Do not forget to do good and to share”. Which comes more naturally to you – the lips or the hands? And how can we make the work of those who “keep watch over your souls” a joy rather than a groaning? (Hebrews 13:15–19)
7. Looking back over the whole series: Hebrews has shown us Jesus as the Son through whom God has spoken, the merciful high priest, the forerunner, the pioneer of faith and now the great shepherd. Which picture of Jesus has become most important to you, and why? (Hebrews 13:20–21)

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Choose one of the directions of love in verses 1–3 and put it into practice this week: invite someone for a meal, visit or write to someone in prison, hospital or a care home, or share something you have with someone in need.
- As the series ends, choose the one verse from Hebrews that has spoken to you most. Write it out, put it where you will see it every day, and tell one person this week why it matters to you.

PRAY TOGETHER

Thank God together for what he has done in the group through this series. Pray for your leaders and for one another, as the author asks in verse 18. Close by turning to one another and speaking verses 20–21 as a blessing over the group, and end with the last words of the letter: “Grace be with you all.”

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- This is the last session: plan extra time for looking back over the series (question 7 and the prayer), even if you choose fewer of the other questions. Verse 2 invites hospitality – consider ending with a meal together.
- 13:4: some in the group are single, divorced or widowed, or live in a painful marriage. Keep the focus on marriage as precious and to be honoured by all, and make sure no one leaves feeling judged. Offer a personal conversation where needed.
- 13:17: some people have been hurt by church leaders. The text describes leaders who keep watch over souls and will give account; the day 28 devotional explains “listen” as letting yourself be persuaded by their word from Scripture. Don't let the evening turn into criticism of particular leaders.
- 13:10 (“We have an altar”): the day 27 devotional reads this as Christ's sacrifice on the cross, in which believers share by faith. If the question of the Lord's Supper comes up, note this reading and leave a longer discussion for another time.
- 13:23 mentions “our brother Timothy”, and some will conclude that Paul wrote the letter. Hebrews names no author; the author calls the whole letter a “word of encouragement” and says he has written “only briefly” – it takes about an hour to read aloud.
- Closing the series: thank the group, ask what they have learned and what they would like to do next, and suggest reading the whole letter aloud in one sitting at home.

Related devotionals: Day 27 – Love in Practice: Contentment, Grace and Going Out to Jesus outside the Camp · Day 28 – The Sacrifice of Praise and the Great Shepherd: Equipped by the God of Peace

Hebrews 13:1–25

[1] Let love for one another as brothers and sisters
continue. [2] Do not forget to show hospitality to
strangers, for by doing so some have enter-
tained angels without knowing it. [3] Remember
those in prison as though you were in prison
with them, and those who are mistreated, since
you yourselves also are in the body. [4] Let mar-
riage be held in honour by all, and the marriage
bed be kept undefiled; for God will judge the
sexually immoral and adulterers. [5] Let your way
of life be free from the love of money; be con-
tent with what you have. For he himself has
said, "I will never let you go and never abandon
you." [6] So we can say with courage:

The Lord is my helper, I will not be afraid.
What can a human being do to me?

[7] Remember your leaders, who spoke the word
of God to you. Consider the outcome of their
way of life, and imitate their faith. [8] Jesus
Christ is yesterday and today the same – and for
ever. [9] Do not be carried away by all kinds of
strange teachings; for it is good for the heart to
be strengthened by grace, not by foods, which
have not benefited those who lived by them.
[10] We have an altar from which those who wor-
ship at the tent have no right to eat. [11] For the
bodies of the animals whose blood is brought
by the high priest into the sanctuary for sin are
burned outside the camp. [12] That is why Jesus
too suffered outside the gate, in order to make
the people holy through his own blood. [13] So let
us go out to him outside the camp, bearing his
reproach. [14] For here we have no city that lasts;
rather, we are seeking the one that is to come.
[15] Through him, then, let us continually offer up
a sacrifice of praise to God, that is, the fruit of
lips that confess his name. [16] Do not forget to do
good and to share, for with such sacrifices God
is pleased.

[17] Listen to your leaders and defer to them, for
they keep watch over your souls as people who
will give account. Let them do this with joy and
not with groaning, for that would be of no ben-
efit to you. [18] Pray for us; for we are convinced
that we have a good conscience, wanting to live
well in every respect. [19] I encourage you all the
more to do this, so that I may be restored to you
sooner.

[20] Now may the God of peace, who brought up
from the dead the great shepherd of the sheep
by the blood of an eternal covenant, our Lord
Jesus, [21] equip you with everything good to do
his will, working in us what is pleasing in his
sight, through Jesus Christ, to whom be the
glory for ever. Amen.

[22] I encourage you, brothers and sisters: bear
with this word of encouragement, for I have
written to you only briefly. [23] You should know
that our brother Timothy has been released; if
he comes soon, I will see you with him. [24] Greet
all your leaders and all the saints. Those from
Italy greet you. [25] Grace be with you all.

SESSION 2 · HEBREWS 2:1–18

Do Not Drift

THE BIG IDEA

Because the Son is so great, we must not drift away from a salvation this great: Jesus became one of us, tasted death for everyone by the grace of God, broke the power of the devil, and is now the merciful and faithful high priest who helps us when we are tested.

TO GET STARTED

Have you ever been on a lilo, a boat or a paddleboard and suddenly noticed how far the current had carried you without your noticing? What happened?

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 2:1–18

Three readers: verses 1–4 (the warning), verses 5–9 (Psalm 8 and Jesus crowned – pause briefly before "But we do see"), verses 10–18 (our brother and high priest).

TIMING

10 min	Welcome & opener
10 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & original language
40 min	Discussion
15 min	Application & prayer

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Chapter 1 showed the Son exalted far above the angels. Now the author turns to the first of five warning passages: if the word spoken through angels at Sinai was binding, how much more the salvation the Lord himself spoke of (vv. 1–4). Then he answers a stumbling block for his Jewish readers – why would the Son become a frail human being and die? – with Psalm 8, showing Jesus as our pioneer, our brother and our high priest (vv. 5–18).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

- ***pararyōmen* – παραρυῶμεν** "drift away": A seafaring word for a boat that has not been properly moored and quietly drifts with the current past the safe harbour – or a ring that slips unnoticed off a finger. Its opposite in the same verse, prosechein (pay attention), meant holding a ship on course and mooring it. The danger is not sudden rebellion but slow, unnoticed drifting (2:1).
- ***archēgos* – ἀρχηγός** "pioneer": A pioneer, trailblazer or champion – like the sailor in a well-known sermon illustration who swims through the breakers to the rocky shore and ties a rescue line, so that everyone on board can cross safely. God made this pioneer "perfect through sufferings": teleioō means fully qualified for his task, not morally improved (2:10).
- ***boētheō* – βοηθέω** "help": Made up of boē (a cry for help) and theō (to run): to rush towards a cry for help. Because he himself suffered when he was tested, Jesus "is able to help those who are being tested" (2:18).

DISCUSSION

1. "How shall we escape if we disregard a salvation this great?" The danger here is not open rebellion but drifting through tiredness and neglect. Which undercurrents in our daily lives pull our attention away from the Lord? (Hebrews 2:1–3)
2. Verses 3–4 give a threefold foundation for this salvation: the Lord who first spoke of it, those who heard him, and God who added his testimony. Why does it help to know that our faith rests on this testimony and not on our feelings? (Hebrews 2:3–4)

3. “As it is, we do not yet see everything subjected to him.” Where do you feel this most painfully – in the world, in your family, in yourself? (Hebrews 2:5–8)
4. “But we do see … Jesus, crowned with glory and honour.” What changes when we shift our gaze from what we do not yet see to the one we do see by faith? (Hebrews 2:8–9)
5. Jesus was made a little lower than the angels “so that by the grace of God he might taste death for everyone”. He did not merely dip his fingertips into death; he drained the cup. What does that mean to you? (Hebrews 2:9)
6. “He is not ashamed to call them brothers and sisters.” When do you feel like the black sheep of God's family? How does verse 11 speak into that? (Hebrews 2:10–13)
7. Verse 15 speaks of people “held in slavery all their lives” through fear of death, and verse 18 promises help to “those who are being tested”. Where does fear – of illness, loss, the future – dictate our decisions? And when you are tempted, do you fight alone first, or call on your high priest straight away? (Hebrews 2:14–18)

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Check your anchor points: choose one daily habit you have let slip (stillness before the Lord, reading the word, fellowship with believers) and moor yourself to it again this week.
- When temptation or fear comes this week, make verse 18 your first response: call to Jesus at once with a short prayer for help, before you try to fight it in your own strength.

PRAY TOGETHER

Read verses 17–18 aloud together. Pray in threes: confess where you have been drifting, thank Jesus that he is not ashamed to call you his brother or sister, and bring him one area where fear or temptation is pressing on you. Close by praying for people you know who are drifting away.

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- Three devotionals (days 3–5) and eighteen verses make a full evening. If time is short, use questions 1, 4, 6 and 7.
- This is the first of five warning passages (2:1–4; 3:7–4:13; 5:11–6:12; 10:19–39; 12:14–29). Its tone is pastoral urgency, not panic. Keep the emphasis of the day 3 devotional: holy watchfulness, and deliberately mooring our hearts to the gospel every day.
- 2:9 “by the grace of God”: our translation follows the majority reading (chariti theou). Some manuscripts and the SBL Greek text read chōris theou (apart from God). Mention it only if someone's Bible reads differently; don't let it become the topic of the evening.
- 2:10 does not mean that Jesus was ever sinful or morally imperfect (see 4:15). Teleioō means bringing someone to the full goal, fully qualifying him for a task – here, to be the Redeemer and high priest of suffering people. Expect this question.
- Fear of death (v. 15) can touch people who are ill, grieving or caring for a dying relative. Handle it gently: the verse is about being set free, not a rebuke for feeling afraid.
- Point ahead: next week chapter 3 – Jesus greater than Moses, and the call “Today, if you hear his voice”.

Related devotionals: Day 3 – The Danger of Drifting: Do Not Disregard a Salvation This Great · Day 4 – Crowned with Glory: Humanity's Destiny and Our Substitute · Day 5 – Our Merciful High Priest: The Pioneer Who Suffers with Us

Hebrews 2:1–18

[1] That is why we must pay much closer attention
to what we have heard, so that we do not drift
away. [2] For if the word spoken through angels
proved binding, and every transgression and
disobedience received a just penalty, [3] how shall
we escape if we disregard a salvation this great?
It began when the Lord spoke of it, and it was
confirmed to us by those who heard, [4] while
God added his testimony by signs and wonders
and various mighty works and by distributions
of the Holy Spirit according to his will.

[5] For it was not to angels that he subjected the
world to come, about which we are speaking.
[6] Rather, someone has testified somewhere:

What is a human being, that you remember
    him,
or a son of man, that you look after him?
[7] You made him a little lower than the angels;
with glory and honour you crowned him;
[8] you subjected everything under his feet.
For in subjecting everything to him, he left
    nothing that is not subject to him. As it is,
    we do not yet see everything subjected to
    him.

[9] But we do see the one who was made a little
lower than the angels, Jesus, crowned with
glory and honour because of the suffering of
death, so that by the grace of God he might
taste death for everyone.

[10] For it was fitting for him, for whose sake ev-
erything exists and through whom everything
exists, in bringing many sons to glory, to make
the pioneer of their salvation perfect through
sufferings. [11] For the one who makes holy and
those who are made holy are all from one. That
is why he is not ashamed to call them brothers
and sisters, [12] saying:

I will declare your name to my brothers and
    sisters;
in the midst of the assembly I will sing your
    praise.

[13] And again:

I will put my trust in him.
And again:
See, here am I, and the children God has given
    me.

[14] Since, then, the children share in blood and
flesh, he too in the same way took part in the
same things, so that through death he might
break the power of the one who holds sway
over death, that is, the devil, [15] and set free all
those who through fear of death were held in
slavery all their lives. [16] For surely he does not
take hold of angels; it is the offspring of
Abraham he takes hold of. [17] Therefore he had
to be made like the brothers and sisters in every
respect, so that he might become a merciful
and faithful high priest before God, to make
atonement for the sins of the people. [18] For be-
cause he himself suffered when he was tested,
he is able to help those who are being tested.

Today

THE BIG IDEA

Jesus, the Son over God's house, is greater than Moses, the faithful servant in it – so we consider him closely, do not harden our hearts when he speaks today, and encourage one another every day, because holding fast to the end shows that we have truly become partners of Christ.

TO GET STARTED

Think of something you kept putting off until tomorrow – a phone call, a repair, a conversation. What happened in the end?

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 3:1–19

Verses 1–6 by one reader; Psalm 95 (vv. 7–11) by a second reader as the voice of the Holy Spirit; verses 12–19 by a third. Let the whole group say the word "Today" together each time it occurs (vv. 7, 13, 15).

TIMING

10 min	Welcome & opener
10 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & original language
40 min	Discussion
15 min	Application & prayer

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

After the prophets and the angels, the author now comes to the greatest figure in Israel's history: Moses. He honours Moses as faithful, then shows that Jesus is the builder and the Son over the house (vv. 1–6). Then he opens the second warning passage with Psalm 95: the generation that saw God's works for forty years still could not enter his rest because of unbelief (vv. 7–19).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

- ***katanoēsate* – κατανοήσατε** "consider closely": Not a quick glance, but fixing your thoughts deeply on something, studying it carefully and getting to the bottom of it. The object is Jesus in his double office as apostle and high priest – the only place in the New Testament where he is called an apostle (3:1).
- ***therapōn* – θεράπων** "servant": Not the ordinary word for a slave (doulos) but an honourable word for a trusted servant and confidant of his master (Numbers 12:7). Moses was faithful in the house as a servant; Christ is faithful as a Son over the house – the heir to whom the whole house belongs (3:5–6).
- ***sklērynō* – σκληρύνω** "harden": The source of the medical term sclerosis: something soft and living gradually stiffens and becomes numb. It happens through the deceitfulness of sin (apatē), which never comes with a warning label (3:8, 13, 15).

DISCUSSION

1. "Consider closely the apostle and high priest of our confession, Jesus." What gets your deepest attention on an ordinary day – and what would it look like to consider Jesus closely this week? (Hebrews 3:1)
2. Moses was faithful as a servant in the house; Christ is faithful "as a Son over his house". The author honours Moses and does not run him down. Which servants in the house – leaders, traditions, churches – are we tempted to build our security on instead of on the Son? (Hebrews 3:2–6)
3. "And we are his house." What does it mean for our group – and for you personally – that God's house is no longer a building of stone but his people? (Hebrews 3:6)
4. The author introduces Psalm 95 with "as the Holy Spirit says" – in the present tense. Is there an area where the Spirit has been speaking to your conscience, while you keep saying: not today, Lord? (Hebrews

3:7–11)

5. The exodus generation saw God's works for forty years and still went astray in their heart. How does hardening happen gradually – and how does "the deceitfulness of sin" work in practice? (Hebrews 3:8–13)
6. God's remedy is shared: "encourage one another every day". Who has the freedom to speak God's truth into your life – and whom could you encourage this week? (Hebrews 3:13)
7. "For we have become partners of Christ – if indeed we hold the assurance we had at the beginning firm to the end." How does this verse comfort us, and how does it challenge us? (Hebrews 3:14–19)

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Take one matter where you have been putting God off until tomorrow, and obey this week – today.
- Encourage one believer every day this week – a message, a call or a word in person that points them to the faithfulness of Christ.

PRAY TOGETHER

Read verses 7–8 aloud together. Pray in pairs: ask the Lord for a soft heart that answers when he calls, name one place where you need to obey today, and pray for each other by name. Close by thanking God together that we are his house.

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- Two devotionals (days 6–7). Verses 7–19 are the centre of the evening; don't spend too long on Moses.
- 3:6 and 3:14 ("if we hold fast …", "if indeed we hold …") touch a question on which Christians hold different convictions: can a true believer finally fall away? The devotionals of days 6–7 read these conditions as showing that perseverance is the evidence of genuine faith: we do not become partners of Christ by persevering at the end; persevering to the end shows that we truly became partners from the beginning. Present this as the devotionals' reading, let members say respectfully how their tradition reads it, and keep the group on what all can agree on: the warning is real, and the remedy is holding fast to Christ and encouraging one another every day.
- Verse 6: some older translations add firm to the end here. Those words are not in the oldest manuscripts; the author does use them in verse 14. If someone's Bible has them in verse 6, that is the reason.
- Meribah and Massah (Exodus 17:1–7): in Hebrew the names mean quarrel and testing; the Greek text that Hebrews quotes has rebellion and testing instead of the names. Our translation follows the Greek, as Hebrews has it.
- Some may hear verse 12 as a verdict on honest doubt. The day 7 devotional makes the distinction: in Hebrews unbelief is not intellectual doubt or an honest wrestling with questions, but a decision of the will to distrust God's promises and shrink back from obedience. Make room for honest questions in the group.
- Point ahead: next week chapter 4 – the promise of rest, the living word of God, and the throne of grace.

Related devotionals: Day 6 – Greater than Moses: The Servant in the House and the Son over the House · Day 7 – Today, If You Hear His Voice: A Warning against a Hardened Heart

Hebrews 3:1–19

[1] Therefore, holy brothers and sisters, partners
in a heavenly calling, consider closely the apos-
tle and high priest of our confession, Jesus. [2] He
is faithful to the one who appointed him, as
Moses also was in his house. [3] For he has been
counted worthy of greater glory than Moses,
just as the builder of a house has greater hon-
our than the house itself. [4] For every house is
built by someone, but the one who built all
things is God. [5] Moses was faithful in all his
house as a servant, to testify to the things that
were to be spoken later, [6] but Christ as a Son
over his house. And we are his house, if we hold
fast to the confidence and the pride we take in
hope.

[7] Therefore, as the Holy Spirit says:

Today, if you hear his voice,
[8] do not harden your hearts as in the rebellion,
on the day of testing in the wilderness,
[9] where your fathers tested me and put me to
the proof
and saw my works
[10] for forty years.
Therefore I was indignant with this generation
and said: They always go astray in their heart;
they have not known my ways.
[11] So I swore in my anger:
They shall never enter my rest!

[12] Take care, brothers and sisters, that none of
you has an evil heart full of unbelief that falls
away from the living God. [13] Rather, encourage
one another every day, as long as it is called
"Today", so that none of you is hardened by the
deceitfulness of sin. [14] For we have become part-
ners of Christ – if indeed we hold the assurance
we had at the beginning firm to the end. [15] As it
is said:

Today, if you hear his voice,
do not harden your hearts as in the rebellion,

[16] who, then, were they who heard and yet re-
belled? Was it not all those who came out of
Egypt led by Moses? [17] And with whom was he
indignant for forty years? Was it not with those
who sinned, whose corpses fell in the wilder-
ness? [18] And to whom did he swear that they
would not enter his rest, if not to those who dis-
obeyed? [19] So we see that they could not enter
because of unbelief.

SESSION 4 · HEBREWS 4:1–16

The Promise of Rest

THE BIG IDEA

A Sabbath rest remains for the people of God: we enter it by faith, not by our own works, under the living word that lays our hearts bare – and we can approach the throne of grace with confidence, because our great high priest sympathizes with our weaknesses.

TO GET STARTED

What does real rest look like for you – not just sleep, but the kind that leaves you truly refreshed? When did you last have it?

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 4:1–16

Two readers take turns with the paragraphs of verses 1–11; one reader reads verses 12–13 slowly; then the whole group reads verses 14–16 together.

TIMING

10 min	Welcome & opener
10 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & original language
40 min	Discussion
15 min	Application & prayer

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Chapter 3 ended with the wilderness generation that could not enter because of unbelief. Now the author brings the warning into the present: the promise of entering God's rest still stands. He links three Old Testament crossroads – God's rest on the seventh day, Joshua and Canaan, and the "Today" of Psalm 95 (vv. 1–11) – then shows the living word that judges the heart (vv. 12–13), and the great high priest who opens the way to the throne of grace (vv. 14–16).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

- ***sabbatismos* – σαββατισμός** "Sabbath rest": Throughout chapters 3–4 the author uses katapausis (rest, a place of rest, such as Canaan). In 4:9 he uses this very rare word for a true, festive Sabbath rest – Hebrews is the earliest known place it occurs, and the author may have coined it. Joshua (in Greek Iēsous, the same name as Jesus) could give only an earthly shadow-rest; the true Jesus brings us into God's own rest.
- ***tetrachēlismena* – τετραχηλισμένα** "laid bare": From trachēlos, neck or throat. In ancient wrestling the verb described a hold that bent the opponent's head back so that he could not look away; some also see an echo of the sacrificial animal inspected by the priest. Before God's eyes all things are "naked and laid bare" (4:13).
- ***sympatheō* – συμπαθέω** "sympathize": Far stronger than our word sympathy: literally to suffer with someone from the inside. Jesus "has been tested in every respect in the same way – yet without sin". Because he never gave in, he felt the full force of temptation (4:15).

DISCUSSION

1. "The word they heard did not benefit them, because they were not united by faith with those who truly heard." The devotional compares this to a meal that is eaten but never digested. How can we hear God's word without it changing us? (Hebrews 4:1–2)
2. Joshua brought Israel into a land, but not into God's final rest; "a Sabbath rest remains for the people of God". What is this rest – and in which area of your life are you still on a spiritual treadmill, working for God's approval instead of living from it? (Hebrews 4:3–10)

3. “Let us therefore make every effort to enter that rest.” How can it take effort to rest? What does the fight of faith look like for you? (Hebrews 4:11)
4. The word of God is “living and effective and sharper than any double-edged sword”. When has a passage of Scripture cut through your excuses? How do you respond when it touches a sore or hidden place? (Hebrews 4:12)
5. “All things are naked and laid bare to the eyes of the one to whom we must give account.” Is that frightening or freeing for you – and why do you think the author follows it immediately with verse 14? (Hebrews 4:13–14)
6. “We do not have a high priest who is unable to sympathize with our weaknesses.” Some think that because Jesus never sinned, he cannot really know how hard temptation is. Why does the devotional say the opposite is true? (Hebrews 4:15)
7. “Let us therefore approach the throne of grace with confidence.” When you have failed, do you picture God's throne as a judge's bench to hide from or as a throne of grace to run to? What do you need today – mercy for the past, or grace for the present? (Hebrews 4:16)

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Choose one area where you are restlessly trying to carry the outcome in your own strength. Each day this week, hand it over to the Lord on purpose and rest in Christ's finished work.
- When you fail or are tempted this week, don't wait until you have cleaned yourself up: go straight to the throne of grace with a short, honest prayer for mercy and grace.

PRAY TOGETHER

Read verse 16 aloud together. Then keep a moment of silence before the living word, and let each person ask the Lord what he wants to lay bare. Pray in pairs for mercy and for help at the right time, and close by praying verse 16 over one another.

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- Two devotionals (days 8 and 9). Day 9 runs on to 5:10; tonight use only its part on 4:14–16 – the rest of it belongs to next week's session on chapter 5.
- 4:2 has two readings in the manuscripts. Our translation reads that they were not united by faith with those who truly heard (Joshua and Caleb); older translations say that the word was not mixed with faith in those who heard it. Both come to the same point: hearing without faith does no good.
- Rest is not laziness or passivity (day 8): we stop working for God's approval and start living from his finished approval in Christ. People with a strong sense of duty may push back; let the effort of verse 11 and the rest of verse 10 stand side by side.
- Verses 12–13 can feel heavy for sensitive consciences. The devotional's picture is a loving surgeon, not an enemy. End the discussion with verses 14–16, so that no one goes home with verse 13 alone.
- Verse 15 may raise speculative questions about Jesus' temptations. Keep to the text's point: he was really tested in every respect and never gave in, and so he truly sympathizes with us.
- Point ahead: next week chapter 5 – Jesus, high priest according to the order of Melchizedek, and the call to move from milk to solid food.

Related devotionals: Day 8 – The Promise of Rest: The Word of God as Judge of Our Hearts · Day 9 – The Throne of Grace: Our Great High Priest Who Can Sympathize with Us

Hebrews 4:1–16

[1] So, since the promise of entering his rest still
stands, let us fear that any of you should seem
to have fallen short. [2] For we too have had the
good news proclaimed to us, just as they did;
but the word they heard did not benefit them,
because they were not united by faith with
those who truly heard. [3] For we who have be-
lieved are entering the rest, just as he has said:

So I swore in my anger:
They shall never enter my rest!
And yet the works had been finished since the
foundation of the world.

[4] For somewhere he has spoken about the sev-
enth day like this: "And God rested on the sev-
enth day from all his works." [5] And again in this
passage: "They shall never enter my rest!"
[6] Since, then, it remains for some to enter it,
and those who first had the good news pro-
claimed to them did not enter because of dis-
obedience, [7] he again sets a certain day –
"Today" – speaking through David so long after-
wards, as has been said before:

Today, if you hear his voice,
do not harden your hearts.

[8] For if Joshua had given them rest, he would
not have spoken afterwards of another day. [9] So
then, a Sabbath rest remains for the people of
God; [10] for whoever has entered his rest has also
rested from his own works, as God did from
his. [11] Let us therefore make every effort to en-
ter that rest, so that no one falls by following
the same example of disobedience.

[12] For the word of God is living and effective and
sharper than any double-edged sword; it
pierces through to the dividing of soul and
spirit, of joints and marrow, and it judges the
thoughts and purposes of the heart. [13] And no
creature is hidden before him, but all things are
naked and laid bare to the eyes of the one to
whom we must give account.

[14] Since, then, we have a great high priest who
has passed through the heavens, Jesus, the Son
of God, let us hold fast to the confession. [15] For
we do not have a high priest who is unable to
sympathize with our weaknesses, but one who
has been tested in every respect in the same
way – yet without sin. [16] Let us therefore ap-
proach the throne of grace with confidence, so
that we may receive mercy and find grace as
help at the right time.

SESSION 5 · HEBREWS 5:1–14

Our Understanding High Priest

THE BIG IDEA

Jesus did not take the honour of high priest for himself: called by God, he learned obedience through what he suffered and became the source of eternal salvation – and he calls us on from milk to solid food, to a faith trained by practice.

TO GET STARTED

Think of a time when someone helped you who had been through the same thing themselves. What made their help different?

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 5:1–14

Read in three parts: verses 1–4 (what every high priest is), verses 5–10 (Christ, Son and priest – let a second reader read the two Psalm quotations), verses 11–14 (milk and solid food).

TIMING

10 min	Welcome & opener
10 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & original language
40 min	Discussion
15 min	Application & prayer

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Chapter 4 ended with an invitation to approach the throne of grace with confidence, because we have a great high priest who can sympathize with our weaknesses (4:14–16). Chapter 5 now explains what makes a true high priest: he is taken from among human beings and called by God – and Jesus fulfils both, right through the tears of Gethsemane. Then the author suddenly stops: before he can say more about Melchizedek, he has to deal with his readers' dull hearing.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

- ***metriopathein* – μετριοπαθεῖν** "deal gently": To keep one's emotions in measure: neither flaring up in anger at those who stumble nor turning away from them coldly. An earthly high priest needed this because he himself was beset with weakness (5:2); Christ had no sin of his own, yet shows perfect gentleness towards sinners.
- ***emathen aph' hōn epathen* – ἔμαθεν ἀφ' ὧν ἔπαθεν** "he learned obedience through what he suffered": A wordplay: he learned (emathen) through what he suffered (epathen). As the eternal Son, Jesus was never disobedient; but as a human being he learned by experience what it costs to stay obedient when obedience costs everything. So he was made perfect – fully qualified – and became the source of eternal salvation (5:8–9).
- ***gegymnasmena* – γεγυμνασμένα** "trained": From gymnazō, which gives us gymnastics and gymnasium. Maturity is not how much we know but faculties trained by practice (hexis, repeated habit) to distinguish good from evil – discernment is built up like muscle, not learned overnight in a classroom (5:14).

DISCUSSION

1. Verses 1–4 name two things every high priest needs: he is "taken from among human beings" and "called by God". Why do both matter for someone who is to stand between us and God? (Hebrews 5:1–4)
2. An earthly high priest could "deal gently with those who are ignorant and going astray, since he himself is beset with weakness". When have you met gentleness like that – neither harsh nor indifferent? What makes it hard to show? (Hebrews 5:2)
3. "Christ did not glorify himself to become high priest." What does it tell us about Jesus that he did not seize this honour but received it from the Father (Psalm 2:7; Psalm 110:4)? (Hebrews 5:4–6)

4. Verse 7 takes us to Gethsemane: “prayers and pleas with loud cries and tears”. What does it mean for your own prayers that Jesus prayed like this? Do you dare to pray that honestly? (Hebrews 5:7)
5. “Although he was a Son, he learned obedience through what he suffered.” Jesus was never disobedient – so what did he learn? And what might God be teaching you in a hard season right now? (Hebrews 5:8–10)
6. The readers had “become sluggish in hearing” – they had not always been like this. How does a believer drift into spiritual sluggishness, and what are the early signs? (Hebrews 5:11–13)
7. Maturity, says verse 14, belongs to those “whose faculties have been trained by practice to distinguish good from evil”. What would your spiritual gym look like this week? (Hebrews 5:14)

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Bring one honest, unpolished prayer to God this week – your real fears and needs, as Jesus prayed “with loud cries and tears” – and remember that your high priest understands.
- Choose one truth you already know (to forgive, to speak the truth when it costs you, to serve someone) and put it into practice in one concrete situation – one session in the spiritual gym.

PRAY TOGETHER

Read verses 7–9 aloud together. Then pray in pairs: thank Jesus that he knows weakness and tears from the inside, name one place where you need his help right now, and ask him to train you to distinguish good from evil. Close by praying for anyone in the group who is going through a hard season.

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- This session draws on two devotionals that cross the chapter boundary: day 9 (4:14–5:10) and day 10 (5:11–6:3). Focus on chapter 5; 4:14–16 is the bridge from last week, and 6:1–3 comes next week.
- Verse 7 says “he was heard because of his reverence” – yet he died. The day 9 devotional answers: God did not save him from dying, but brought him through death and out of death in the resurrection. (Some take the phrase to mean that he was heard and set free from his anguish.)
- Verse 8 can sound as if Jesus was once disobedient. Make clear, with day 9: as the eternal Son he never rebelled; in becoming human he learned by experience what obedience costs. Don't let the evening become a long debate about the two natures of Christ.
- People who are suffering may hear verse 8 as a verdict on their pain. Handle it gently: day 9 says that present suffering is not a sign that God has forgotten us, but a classroom in which the Spirit shapes us – it does not say that every hardship is deserved.
- Questions 6–7 can feel like a rebuke. Long-standing members may feel judged, and new believers may feel they are being called babies. Day 10 says milk is natural and healthy for a newborn; the problem is only staying there. Keep the tone encouraging.
- Point ahead: next week chapter 6 – the sternest warning of the letter (6:4–6), and hope as the anchor of the soul.

Related devotionals: Day 9 – The Throne of Grace: Our Great High Priest Who Can Sympathize with Us · Day 10 – From Milk to Solid Food: A Warning against Spiritual Stagnation

Hebrews 5:1–14

[1] For every high priest is taken from among human beings and appointed on behalf of human beings in what is to be done before God, to offer gifts and sacrifices for sins. [2] He is able to deal gently with those who are ignorant and going astray, since he himself is beset with weakness. [3] Because of this he must offer sacrifices for sins for himself as well as for the people. [4] And no one takes this honour for himself; he is called by God, just as Aaron was.

[5] So also Christ did not glorify himself to become high priest; it was the one who said to him:

You are my Son;
today I have fathered you,

[6] as he also says in another place:

You are a priest for ever
according to the order of Melchizedek.

[7] In the days of his flesh he offered up prayers and pleas with loud cries and tears to the one who was able to save him out of death, and he was heard because of his reverence. [8] Although he was a Son, he learned obedience through what he suffered; [9] and having been made perfect, he became the source of eternal salvation for all who obey him, [10] addressed by God as high priest according to the order of Melchizedek.

[11] About this we have much to say, and it is hard to explain, since you have become sluggish in hearing. [12] For though by this time you ought to be teachers, you again need someone to teach you the first basics of the words of God; you have become people who need milk, not solid food. [13] For everyone who still lives on milk is unacquainted with the word of righteousness, for he is an infant. [14] But solid food is for the mature, whose faculties have been trained by practice to distinguish good from evil.

SESSION 6 · HEBREWS 6:1–20

The Soul's Anchor

THE BIG IDEA

Don't stand still at the foundation: the author warns earnestly against falling away, yet he is convinced of better things for his readers – and our hope rests on God's promise and God's oath, an anchor fixed behind the curtain where Jesus has gone ahead of us.

TO GET STARTED

Think of something you once had to wait a long time for. What helped you keep going – or what made you want to give up?

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 6:1–20

Read in four parts with four readers: verses 1–3, verses 4–8 (read slowly and calmly, not threateningly), verses 9–12 (read warmly), verses 13–20 (the oath and the anchor).

TIMING

10 min	Welcome & opener
10 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & original language
40 min	Discussion
15 min	Application & prayer

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

At the end of chapter 5 the author stopped to rebuke his readers: they had become sluggish in hearing and still needed milk. Chapter 6 calls them on to maturity (vv. 1–3) and then gives one of the sternest warnings in the letter (vv. 4–8). But straight away he calls them "dear friends" and assures them of better things (vv. 9–12), before pointing them to God's oath to Abraham and to the hope that is an anchor of the soul (vv. 13–20).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

- ***nōthroi* – νωθροί** "sluggish": Dull, listless, numb. The word frames the passage: in 5:11 the readers have "become sluggish in hearing", and in 6:12 the author urges them not to become sluggish but to imitate those who inherit the promises. Its opposite is eagerness, faith and patience (makrothymia, a long breath).
- ***ametathetos* – ἀμετάθετος** "unchangeable": A word used in legal language for a will or agreement that cannot be cancelled or altered. God's word was already enough, but for the sake of our doubt he added an oath – two unchangeable things, "in which it is impossible for God to lie" (6:17–18).
- ***prodromos* – πρόδρομος** "forerunner": Under the old covenant the high priest went behind the curtain alone, once a year, and no one could follow him. Jesus has entered "as a forerunner on our behalf": he has gone ahead to open the way, so that we may follow him into God's presence (6:20).

DISCUSSION

1. Verses 1–2 name six foundation stones in three pairs. Which of them were laid well in your own life? Why must we not keep laying the foundation again – and what does "if indeed God permits" add? (Hebrews 6:1–3)
2. Verses 4–5 describe people who "have once been enlightened" and "have tasted the heavenly gift". How can someone experience so much at close quarters and still turn away? (Think of the wilderness generation in chapter 3.) (Hebrews 6:4–5)
3. Verse 6 describes people who keep on "crucifying the Son of God again for themselves and holding him up to contempt". Why does it matter that the impossibility is tied to an ongoing rejection of Jesus, the

only high priest and the only sacrifice? (Hebrews 6:6)

4. Two pieces of land drink the same rain: one produces useful vegetation, the other thorns and thistles. What does the spiritual rain in your life look like, and what is it producing? (Hebrews 6:7–8)
5. Right after the warning the author says: “we are convinced of better things in your case”. What does he see in his readers (v. 10)? Where do you see “things that belong to salvation” in one another? (Hebrews 6:9–10)
6. “For God is not unjust; he will not forget your work and the love you have shown for his name.” Whose hidden service do you want to thank God for tonight? What does this verse say to someone who feels unnoticed? (Hebrews 6:10–12)
7. Our hope is “an anchor of the soul, sure and firm” – but it is cast upwards, behind the curtain, not down into the sea. What is your anchor fastened to when the storm comes, and what difference does it make that Jesus has gone there ahead of us? (Hebrews 6:13–20)

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Abraham obtained the promise “after waiting patiently”. Name one promise of God you are waiting on, and each day this week bring it before him again with faith and patience.
- Encourage one person whose service usually goes unnoticed – tell them, in a note or in person, that God does not forget their work and their love.

PRAY TOGETHER

Read verses 19–20 aloud together. Then pray in pairs for each other: name one storm or one long wait you are in, and thank God that his promise and his oath cannot fail. Close by thanking God for the faithful, hidden service of people in your church.

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- This session draws on three devotionals: day 10 (5:11–6:3, for verses 1–3), day 11 (6:4–12) and day 12 (6:13–20). Don't let verses 4–6 swallow the whole evening – keep at least 15 minutes for the oath and the anchor (vv. 13–20).
- 6:4–6 is one of the most debated passages in the New Testament, and sincere Christians in your group may read it differently, depending on their tradition. Let each person speak without having to settle the question; the aim is to hear the warning and the comfort together, not to win a debate.
- Follow the line of the day 11 devotional: the readers were considering openly denying Christ and going back to the temple sacrifices to escape persecution; falling away here means a total, deliberate rejection of Christ, not a believer stumbling into sin out of weakness; and the present participles tie the impossibility to persisting in that rejection. There is no other sacrifice.
- Someone may be afraid of having committed this sin. Say clearly what day 11 says: the very fact that your heart is tender, that you grieve over your sin and long for Jesus, shows that you are not in the hardened state of verse 6. If the fear runs deep, offer to talk and pray together afterwards.
- Verse 9 is the author's own key: the only time in the letter he calls his readers “dear friends”, and he is convinced of better things in their case. Never read the warning without verses 9–12.
- Background (day 12): the anchor was found on early Christian graves; the popular sermon story of a small boat rowing the anchor into the harbour has no clear ancient evidence – use it as an illustration, not as history. Point ahead: next week chapter 7 – Melchizedek and a priest for ever.

Related devotionals: Day 10 – From Milk to Solid Food: A Warning against Spiritual Stagnation · Day 11 – Earnestness and Perseverance: Inheriting the Promises through Faith and Patience · Day 12 – God's Unchangeable Oath: The Sure and Firm Anchor of Our Soul

Hebrews 6:1–20

1 So let us leave behind the elementary word
about Christ and be carried on to maturity, not
laying again a foundation of repentance from
dead works and of faith in God, 2 of teaching
about washings and laying on of hands, about
the resurrection of the dead and eternal judg-
ment. 3 And this we will do, if indeed God
permits.

4 For it is impossible for those who have once
been enlightened, who have tasted the heav-
enly gift and have become partners of the Holy
Spirit, 5 who have tasted the goodness of the
word of God and the powers of the age to come,
6 and who have fallen away, to be renewed again
to repentance – crucifying the Son of God again
for themselves and holding him up to con-
tempt. 7 For land that drinks the rain that often
falls on it, and produces vegetation useful to
those for whose sake it is cultivated, receives a
blessing from God. 8 But if it bears thorns and
thistles, it fails the test and is close to being
cursed, and its end is to be burned.

9 But even though we speak like this, dear
friends, we are convinced of better things in
your case, things that belong to salvation. 10 For
God is not unjust; he will not forget your work
and the love you have shown for his name when
you served the saints, as you still serve them.
11 And we long for each one of you to show the
same eagerness for the full assurance of hope to
the end, 12 so that you do not become sluggish,
but imitate those who through faith and pa-
tience inherit the promises.

13 For when God made his promise to Abraham,
since he had no one greater by whom to swear,
he swore by himself, 14 saying: "I will surely
bless you and surely multiply you." 15 And so, af-
ter waiting patiently, Abraham obtained the
promise. 16 For people swear by someone
greater than themselves, and for them an oath
is the end of every dispute, as confirmation.
17 In the same way God, wanting to show even
more clearly to the heirs of the promise how
unchangeable his purpose was, guaranteed it
with an oath, 18 so that through two unchange-
able things, in which it is impossible for God to
lie, we who have fled for refuge might have
strong encouragement to hold fast to the hope
set before us. 19 We have this hope as an anchor
of the soul, sure and firm, and it enters the in-
ner place behind the curtain, 20 where Jesus has
entered as a forerunner on our behalf, having
become high priest for ever according to the or-
der of Melchizedek.

SESSION 7 · HEBREWS 7:1–28

A Priest for Ever

THE BIG IDEA

Melchizedek, without genealogy and greater than Abraham, points to Jesus: a priest not by descent but by the power of an indestructible life and by God's oath, who always lives to intercede for us and who offered himself once for all.

TO GET STARTED

Have you ever had to start again with a new doctor, teacher or adviser because the old one left? What was lost?

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 7:1–28

First let someone read Genesis 14:18–20. Then read Hebrews 7 in three parts: verses 1–10 (Melchizedek and Abraham), verses 11–22 (another priest and a sworn oath), verses 23–28 (a priest who always lives – read verse 25 slowly).

TIMING

10 min	Welcome & opener
10 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & original language
40 min	Discussion
15 min	Application & prayer

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

At the end of chapter 6 Jesus entered behind the curtain as our forerunner, high priest for ever according to the order of Melchizedek. Now the author finally opens the subject he has been circling since 5:6–10. For Jewish believers it raised a fair question: how can Jesus be a priest if he came from the tribe of Judah and not from Levi? The author answers from the only two places in the Old Testament where Melchizedek appears: Genesis 14:18–20 and Psalm 110:4.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

- ***agenealogētos* – ἀγενεαλόγητος** "without genealogy": Genesis introduces almost every important figure with ancestors, birth and death – but not Melchizedek. He is not an angel or an appearance of Christ; the author reads the silence of Scripture: in the text Melchizedek is "made like the Son of God", a portrait painted in advance of the Original (7:3).
- ***engyos* – ἔγγυος** "guarantor": Found only here in the New Testament (7:22). A mediator negotiates between two parties; a guarantor puts his own life, property and honour at stake that the terms will be kept – if we fail, the guarantor pays. Jesus was appointed with God's sworn oath, and so he guarantees a better covenant.
- ***eis to panteles* – εἰς τὸ παντελές** "completely": The phrase has a double shade: completely, to the deepest corner of our brokenness, and for all time, to the very end. He can save like this "since he always lives to intercede for them" (7:25).

DISCUSSION

1. Melchizedek is first "king of righteousness" and then "king of peace". Why does the order matter? Where do we look for peace without letting righteousness touch the matter? (Hebrews 7:1–2)
2. Genesis is silent about Melchizedek's parents, birth and death, and the author sees in that silence a portrait of the Son of God. How does it free us that Jesus' priesthood – and his blessing – do not depend on pedigree, background or a spiritual CV? (Hebrews 7:3)
3. "See how great he is." Abraham gave a tenth of the best of the spoils – centuries before the law, out of gratitude. What would it mean for you to give Jesus the best part of your time and your heart rather

than the leftovers? (Hebrews 7:4–10)

4. Verse 19 says “the law made nothing perfect”, but “a better hope is brought in, through which we draw near to God”. Where are you tempted to rely on a list of rules instead of drawing near? (Hebrews 7:11–19)
5. Jesus became a priest “according to the power of an indestructible life” and with a sworn oath. What does his resurrection – and God's oath – have to do with your confidence before God? (Hebrews 7:16–22)
6. The former priests were many “because they were prevented by death from continuing in office”, but Jesus “holds his priesthood permanently”. What does it mean for you that your high priest never retires and never has to be replaced? (Hebrews 7:23–24)
7. “He is able to save completely those who approach God through him, since he always lives to intercede for them.” Is there a part of your life you secretly think is beyond his reach? What does verse 25 say to it? (Hebrews 7:25–28)

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Each morning this week, remind yourself that Jesus is interceding for you today, and bring him one thing you fear you cannot manage.
- When old guilt comes back this week, remember that he did it “once for all when he offered up himself” – and refuse to add your own self-punishment to his sacrifice.

PRAY TOGETHER

Read verses 24–25 aloud together. Then pray in pairs: thank Jesus that he is your guarantor and that he is praying for you now, and name before him one area you think is beyond his reach. Close with thanks for his once-for-all sacrifice (v. 27).

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- This session covers two devotionals: day 13 (7:1–10) and day 14 (7:11–28). Chapter 7 is a sustained argument; reading Genesis 14:18–20 first helps the group know the story the author builds on.
- Verse 3 often raises the question whether Melchizedek was an angel or Christ himself before the incarnation. The day 13 devotional says no: he was a historical king of Salem, and the point lies in the silence of Genesis about his origins. Answer briefly and move on.
- Verses 9–10 (Levi still in his ancestor's body) can sound strange to modern ears. Explain briefly with day 13: the father of the whole nation acknowledged a greater priesthood, and through him Levi himself, as it were, bowed before it.
- The tenth (vv. 4–10) can turn into a sensitive conversation about money. Day 13's point is Abraham's free, grateful giving of the best part – before any law – applied to time, gifts, attention and means. Don't let the evening become a discussion of church finances, and don't put anyone under pressure.
- Some in the group may struggle with assurance or lingering guilt. Let verses 22, 25 and 27 do the work: with day 14, our perseverance does not rest on the strength of our grip but on Jesus as guarantor and intercessor, and nothing can be added to his sacrifice.
- Point ahead: next week chapter 8 – the true tent and a better covenant.

Related devotionals: Day 13 – The Order of Melchizedek: King of Righteousness and King of Peace · Day 14 – A Permanent Priesthood: Christ Who Is Able to Save Completely

Hebrews 7:1–28

[1] For this Melchizedek, king of Salem, priest of
God Most High, met Abraham as he was return-
ing from the defeat of the kings and blessed
him, [2] and Abraham gave him a tenth of every-
thing. His name means first "king of righteous-
ness", and then he is also king of Salem, that is,
"king of peace". [3] Without father, without
mother, without genealogy, having neither be-
ginning of days nor end of life, but made like
the Son of God, he remains a priest for all time.

[4] See how great he is, to whom Abraham the pa-
triarch gave a tenth of the best of the spoils.
[5] Those of the sons of Levi who receive the
priestly office have a commandment in the law
to collect a tenth from the people, that is, from
their brothers and sisters, though these too
have come from Abraham's body. [6] But this
man, who does not trace his descent from
them, collected a tenth from Abraham and
blessed the one who had the promises. [7] Beyond
all dispute, the lesser is blessed by the better.
[8] Here, mortal men receive tithes; there, one of
whom it is testified that he lives. [9] And one
might even say that Levi himself, who receives
tithes, paid a tenth through Abraham, [10] for he
was still in his ancestor's body when
Melchizedek met him.

[11] Now if perfection had come through the
Levitical priesthood – for on the basis of it the
people received the law – what further need
would there have been for another priest to
arise according to the order of Melchizedek,
and not to be named according to the order of
Aaron? [12] For when the priesthood is changed,
there is of necessity a change of law as well.
[13] For the one of whom these things are said be-
longed to another tribe, from which no one has
ever served at the altar. [14] For it is clear that our
Lord has arisen from Judah, and in connection
with that tribe Moses said nothing about
priests.

[15] And it is even more evident if another priest
arises in the likeness of Melchizedek, [16] who has
become a priest not according to a law of a
fleshly commandment but according to the
power of an indestructible life. [17] For it is
testified:

You are a priest for ever
according to the order of Melchizedek.

[18] For on the one hand, a former commandment
is set aside because of its weakness and useless-
ness [19] – for the law made nothing perfect – and
on the other hand, a better hope is brought in,
through which we draw near to God.

[20] And it was not without a sworn oath. For the
others became priests without a sworn oath,
[21] but he with a sworn oath, through the one
who said to him:

The Lord has sworn
and will not change his mind:
You are a priest for ever.

[22] So much the more has Jesus become the guar-
antor of a better covenant.

[23] The former priests were many in number, be-
cause they were prevented by death from con-
tinuing in office; [24] but he, because he remains
for ever, holds his priesthood permanently.
[25] That is why he is able to save completely those
who approach God through him, since he al-
ways lives to intercede for them.

[26] For it was fitting that we should have such a
high priest: holy, innocent, undefiled, sepa-
rated from sinners, and become higher than
the heavens. [27] He has no need, like the high
priests, to offer up sacrifices day after day, first
for his own sins and then for those of the peo-
ple; for this he did once for all when he offered
up himself. [28] For the law appoints as high
priests men who have weakness, but the word

of the sworn oath, which came after the law,
appoints a Son, made perfect for ever.

SESSION 8 · HEBREWS 8:1–13

Shadow and Reality

THE BIG IDEA

We have a high priest who has sat down in the true tent and is mediator of a better covenant, whose promises rest on God's own "I will": he writes his laws on our hearts and remembers our sins no more.

TO GET STARTED

Have you ever seen an architect's model or a sketch of a house before it was built? How did the real building compare with it?

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 8:1–13

Two readers: one reads verses 1–7 and verse 13; the other reads the Jeremiah quotation in verses 8–12 as the voice of the Lord – slowly, with a short pause after each "I will".

TIMING

10 min	Welcome & opener
10 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & original language
40 min	Discussion
15 min	Application & prayer

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

In chapter 7 the author showed that the person of our high priest, according to the order of Melchizedek, is far higher than the Levitical priests. Now chapter 8 turns to his ministry: a better sanctuary and a better covenant. For the first readers, cut off from the temple in Jerusalem and perhaps mocked for having no temple, no priest and no altar, this was a burning question. The author answers with the longest Old Testament quotation in the New Testament, Jeremiah 31:31–34, quoted as the Greek translation has it.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

- ***kephalaion* – κεφάλαιον** "the main point": Not just a summary but the crowning point of the whole argument (8:1). And the core is a seated high priest: the earthly priests had to stand every day because their work was never finished (cf. 10:11); ours has taken his seat.
- ***hypodeigma kai skia* – ὑπόδειγμα καὶ σκιά** "copy and shadow": A hypodeigma is a copy or sketch; Moses had to build according to the typos, the pattern or blueprint shown on the mountain (8:5). Like a shadow on the ground or an architect's scale model, the tent worship was good and God-given, but it pointed to a greater reality: Christ's ministry in heaven.
- ***diathēkē kainē* – διαθήκη καινή** "a new covenant": Kainos is often distinguished from neos: not only new in time but new in kind (the distinction is not strict – in 12:24 Hebrews also uses nea). Its promises are better because God no longer says "If you …" but "I will!" (8:8–12).

DISCUSSION

1. The main point is this: "we have such a high priest, who took his seat at the right hand of the throne of the Majesty in the heavens". Why would the author make a seated priest the core of his whole argument? (Hebrews 8:1–2)
2. The earthly priests serve "a copy and shadow of the heavenly things". The first readers had lost the visible temple. Which visible things – forms, rituals, human approval – do we lean on for our spiritual security? (Hebrews 8:3–5)
3. If the first covenant had been faultless, there would have been no need for a second. Read verse 8: "For he finds fault with them when he says". Where did the fault lie – and what did the old covenant not give? (Hebrews 8:6–9)

4. “I will put my laws into their minds, and I will write them on their hearts.” Do you experience God's will at the moment more like tablets of stone – an outward burden – or like something the Spirit is writing within you? What makes the difference? (Hebrews 8:10)
5. “For they shall all know me, from the least of them to the greatest.” Under the old covenant ordinary people depended on prophets, priests and kings. What does it mean for the youngest and the oldest in our group that each can know the Lord personally? (Hebrews 8:11)
6. Verse 12 begins with “For”: everything rests on it. “For I will be merciful toward their unrighteous deeds, and I will remember their sins no more.” The Greek uses a double negative – never, ever again. Is there a sin you have confessed long ago but still accuse yourself of? What would change if you believed this verse? (Hebrews 8:12)
7. “What is becoming old and growing aged is close to disappearing.” How can we honour the first covenant as God-given and still not go back to the shadows? (Hebrews 8:13)

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Each morning this week pray verse 10 for one specific area of your life where you are pushing yourself with clenched teeth: ask the Lord to write his will there on your heart and to change your desires from within.
- Write down one old, confessed sin that you keep digging up. Read verse 12 aloud over it, thank God that he will never again use it against you – and then tear up the paper.

PRAY TOGETHER

Read verses 10–12 aloud together. Then pray in twos or threes: thank Jesus that he has sat down as our high priest in the true tent, ask him to write his laws on your hearts, and thank the Father, in your own words, for the promise of verse 12. Leave a moment of silence for each person to receive it personally.

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- This session draws on a single devotional (day 15) for the whole chapter, so there is time for the Jeremiah quotation. Choose five or six questions; do not skip the question on verse 12.
- Hebrews quotes Jeremiah as the Greek (Septuagint) has it. In 8:9 our text reads “and I disregarded them”, where the Hebrew of Jeremiah 31:32 says although I was their husband (or master). If someone's Bible reads differently, this is the reason – our translation follows the Greek of Hebrews on purpose.
- The devotional is clear that the fault lay not with God or his holy law but with sinful people (8:8). The tent was built at God's instruction (8:5). Keep the evening from turning into contempt for the Old Testament or for the Jewish people.
- Verse 12 does not mean that the all-knowing God suffers memory loss; it means that he promises never again to use our confessed sin against us or to treat us according to our past. For some, the question on verse 12 touches deep guilt – allow silence and offer to pray with anyone afterwards.
- Verse 13: many think the letter was written before AD 70, when the temple was indeed close to disappearing. That is interesting background, but don't let dating questions take over the discussion.
- Point ahead: next week chapter 9 – a guided tour of the earthly tent, and then “But Christ …”: through his own blood.

Related devotionals: Day 15 – The True Tent and a Better Covenant: Shadow and Reality

Hebrews 8:1–13

1 The main point of what we are saying is this:
we have such a high priest, who took his seat at
the right hand of the throne of the Majesty in
the heavens, 2 a minister in the sanctuary and
in the true tent, which the Lord pitched, not a
human being. 3 For every high priest is ap-
pointed to offer gifts and sacrifices; so it is nec-
essary for this one too to have something to of-
fer. 4 Now if he were on earth, he would not
even be a priest, since there are those who offer
the gifts according to the law. 5 They worship at
a copy and shadow of the heavenly things, just
as Moses was instructed when he was about to
complete the tent: "See," he says, "that you
make everything according to the pattern that
was shown you on the mountain." 6 But as it is,
he has obtained a ministry that is as much supe-
rior as he is also mediator of a better covenant,
which has been enacted on better promises.

7 For if that first covenant had been faultless, no
place would have been sought for a second.
8 For he finds fault with them when he says:

See, days are coming, says the Lord,
when I will bring about a new covenant
with the house of Israel and with the house of
Judah,
9 not like the covenant that I made with their
fathers
on the day when I took hold of their hand
to lead them out of the land of Egypt;
for they did not remain in my covenant,
and I disregarded them, says the Lord.
10 For this is the covenant that I will make with
the house of Israel
after those days, says the Lord:
I will put my laws into their minds,
and I will write them on their hearts;
and I will be their God,
and they shall be my people.
11 And they shall not teach, each one his fellow
citizen
and each one his brother, saying: Know the
Lord,
for they shall all know me,
from the least of them to the greatest.
12 For I will be merciful toward their unrigh-
teous deeds,
and I will remember their sins no more.

13 By saying "new", he has made the first one old;
and what is becoming old and growing aged is
close to disappearing.

SESSION 9 · HEBREWS 9:1–28

Through His Own Blood

THE BIG IDEA

The earthly tent showed that the way into God's presence was not yet open; Christ entered the sanctuary once for all through his own blood, cleanses our conscience from dead works so that we may worship the living God, appears now before God for us and will appear a second time for salvation.

TO GET STARTED

Think of a place you were not allowed into as a child – a staff room, a workshop, your parents' study. What did that closed door say to you?

TIMING

10 min	Welcome & opener
10 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & original language
40 min	Discussion
15 min	Application & prayer

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 9:1–28

Three readers: verses 1–10 (the earthly tent – read slowly, like a guided tour), verses 11–14 (Christ's own blood – stress the word "But" at the start), verses 15–28 (the will, the blood and the three appearings).

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

At the end of chapter 8 God declared the first covenant old. Now the author takes us on a reverent tour of the wilderness tent of Moses: two compartments, a heavy curtain, one high priest, once a year, never without blood. Then come two powerful words: "But Christ …". Chapter 9 shows what his own blood achieves that no animal sacrifice could, why a death was necessary – the covenant also works like a will – and how Christ appears for us in the past, the present and the future.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

- ***syneidēsis* – συνείδησις** "conscience": Literally knowing together with oneself: our inner moral awareness that we stand guilty before a holy God. Gifts and sacrifices could not make the worshipper perfect with respect to conscience (9:9); the blood of Christ will cleanse our conscience from dead works (9:14).
- ***lytrōsis* – λύτρωσις** "redemption": Buying the freedom of a slave or prisoner of war by paying a costly ransom. The Old Testament knew only a yearly atonement; Christ entered once for all (ephapax) and obtained eternal redemption, whose value never expires (9:12).
- ***diathēkē* – διαθήκη** "covenant / will": The same Greek word means both covenant and last will and testament. Our translation renders it "will" in 9:16–17 and "covenant" elsewhere, so that the change of meaning can be seen: a will takes effect only when the one who made it has died – and Christ leaves us the promise of the eternal inheritance (9:15).

DISCUSSION

1. Walk through the tent in verses 1–5. Inside the ark lay reminders of the people's grumbling, rebellion and broken law – and above it the atonement cover where the blood was sprinkled. What does that picture tell you about God? (Hebrews 9:1–5)
2. "But into the second only the high priest goes, once a year, and not without blood." According to verse 8, what was the Holy Spirit teaching through this design? Does your relationship with God sometimes still feel like standing before a closed curtain? (Hebrews 9:6–8)

3. Gifts and sacrifices "cannot make the worshipper perfect with respect to conscience"; they cleanse only the outside. Which outward "washings" do we use today to quiet a guilty conscience – extra effort, good resolutions, days of self-reproach? (Hebrews 9:9–10)
4. "How much more will the blood of Christ … cleanse our conscience from dead works to worship the living God!" Notice the order: cleansed so that we may serve, not serving so that we may be cleansed. What changes when you live in that order? (Hebrews 9:11–14)
5. In verse 14 the whole Trinity is at work: the Son offered himself, through the eternal Spirit, to God. What does it mean to you that your salvation is the work of Father, Son and Spirit together? (Hebrews 9:14)
6. "For a will takes effect only at death." And verse 22: "without the shedding of blood there is no forgiveness". Why did the Messiah have to die – could God not simply have declared us forgiven? What does it mean that no one can contest the inheritance Christ has left you? (Hebrews 9:15–22)
7. Verses 24–28 speak of three appearings: once at the end of the ages to set aside sin (past), "now to appear in the presence of God on our behalf" (present), and a second time, apart from sin, for salvation (future). Which of the three do you need most this week, and why? (Hebrews 9:23–28)

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- When your conscience accuses you this week, don't do penance: name the sin before God, thank him for the blood of Christ (9:14) – and then do one act of service for someone, freely and gratefully.
- Begin each day this week by reminding yourself of verse 24: Christ is now in the presence of God on your behalf. Then bring your day to the Father with that confidence.

PRAY TOGETHER

Read verse 14 aloud together. Pray in short sentences: thank God for one thing in the tent that points to Christ, confess quietly any dead works you rely on, and thank Jesus that he appears for us now. Close with verse 28: thank him that he will appear a second time for salvation.

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- This session draws on three devotionals (days 16–18), and chapter 9 is long. Choose five questions. Don't get lost in the details of the furniture – the author himself says in 9:5: "Of these things we cannot now speak in detail."
- Someone may notice that in Exodus 30:6 the altar of incense stood in front of the curtain, while 9:4 says the Most Holy Place "had" it. The day 16 devotional explains: it belonged to the Most Holy Place in its function – its smoke was meant to fill it, and on the Day of Atonement the high priest carried the censer inside (Leviticus 16:12–13).
- 9:16–17 uses "will" and the rest of the chapter "covenant" – this is the same Greek word, rendered so on purpose (series decision). If the group's Bibles differ, explain the play on words rather than debating translations.
- Some find the talk of blood difficult or off-putting. The devotional explains it from Leviticus 17:11 (the life of the flesh is in the blood): sin is not a small mistake, and forgiveness requires that a substitute life be laid down. Give people space to ask honest questions.
- Verse 27 (to die once, and after that judgment) can hit hard for someone who is grieving or anxious about death. The devotional never leaves verse 27 on its own: verse 28 follows immediately – "just as … so Christ also". For those in Christ the future is joyful expectation.
- Point ahead: next week chapter 10 – one sacrifice for all time, the new and living way, and a serious warning (10:26–31) followed by "do not throw away your confidence".

Related devotionals: Day 16 – The Earthly Sanctuary: The Limits of the Old Order and the Conscience · Day 17 – Through His Own Blood: Eternal Redemption and a Cleansed Conscience · Day 18 – The Will and the Blood: Offered Once to Bear the Sins of Many

Hebrews 9:1–28

1 Now even the first covenant had regulations
for worship and an earthly sanctuary. 2 For a
tent was set up, the first one, in which were the
lampstand and the table and the loaves set out;
this is called the Holy Place. 3 Behind the sec-
ond curtain was a tent called the Most Holy
Place. 4 It had a golden altar of incense and the
ark of the covenant, covered on all sides with
gold, in which were a golden jar holding the
manna, and Aaron's staff that had budded, and
the tablets of the covenant. 5 Above it were the
cherubim of glory, overshadowing the atone-
ment cover. Of these things we cannot now
speak in detail.

6 With these things set up in this way, the
priests go continually into the first tent to carry
out their acts of worship, 7 but into the second
only the high priest goes, once a year, and not
without blood, which he offers for himself and
for the sins the people have committed in igno-
rance. 8 By this the Holy Spirit makes clear that
the way into the sanctuary has not yet been re-
vealed while the first tent still has standing.
9 This is a symbol for the present time, accord-
ing to which gifts and sacrifices are offered that
cannot make the worshipper perfect with re-
spect to conscience, 10 since they deal only with
food and drink and various washings – regula-
tions for the flesh, imposed until the time of
setting things right.

11 But when Christ came as high priest of the
good things that have come, through the
greater and more perfect tent, not made with
hands, that is, not of this creation, 12 not
through the blood of goats and calves but
through his own blood, he entered the sanctu-
ary once for all and obtained eternal redemp-
tion. 13 For if the blood of goats and bulls and
the sprinkled ashes of a heifer make holy those
who have been defiled, so that their flesh is
clean, 14 how much more will the blood of
Christ, who through the eternal Spirit offered
himself without blemish to God, cleanse our
conscience from dead works to worship the liv-
ing God!

15 And for this reason he is mediator of a new
covenant, so that, since a death has taken place
for redemption from the transgressions com-
mitted under the first covenant, those who are
called may receive the promise of the eternal
inheritance. 16 For where there is a will, the
death of the one who made it must be estab-
lished. 17 For a will takes effect only at death,
since it is never in force while the one who
made it is alive. 18 That is why not even the first
covenant was inaugurated without blood. 19 For
when every commandment had been spoken by
Moses to all the people according to the law, he
took the blood of the calves with water and
scarlet wool and hyssop, and sprinkled both the
book itself and all the people, 20 saying: "This is
the blood of the covenant that God has com-
manded for you." 21 In the same way he sprin-
kled with the blood the tent and all the vessels
used in the ministry. 22 Indeed, according to the
law almost everything is cleansed with blood,
and without the shedding of blood there is no
forgiveness.

23 So it was necessary for the copies of the
things in the heavens to be cleansed with these,
but the heavenly things themselves with better
sacrifices than these. 24 For Christ did not enter
a sanctuary made with hands, a counterpart of
the true one, but into heaven itself, now to ap-
pear in the presence of God on our behalf.
25 Nor did he enter to offer himself again and
again, as the high priest enters the sanctuary
year by year with blood that is not his own;
26 for then he would have had to suffer again
and again since the foundation of the world.
But as it is, he has been revealed once at the end
of the ages to set aside sin by his sacrifice. 27 And

just as it is in store for human beings to die once, and after that comes judgment, [28] so Christ also, having been offered once to bear the sins of many, will appear a second time, apart from sin, to those who eagerly wait for him, for salvation.